

No-Nonsense Filmmaking

NO-NONSENSE FILMMAKING

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The Beginning of Something Else

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The Beginning of Something

Hello there, and welcome to No-Nonsense Filmmaking!

As you join a global community of artists, technicians, and storytellers, we hope to get you started on what will be a lifetime of interesting conversations and endless curiosity, as well as a lifelong search for knowledge.

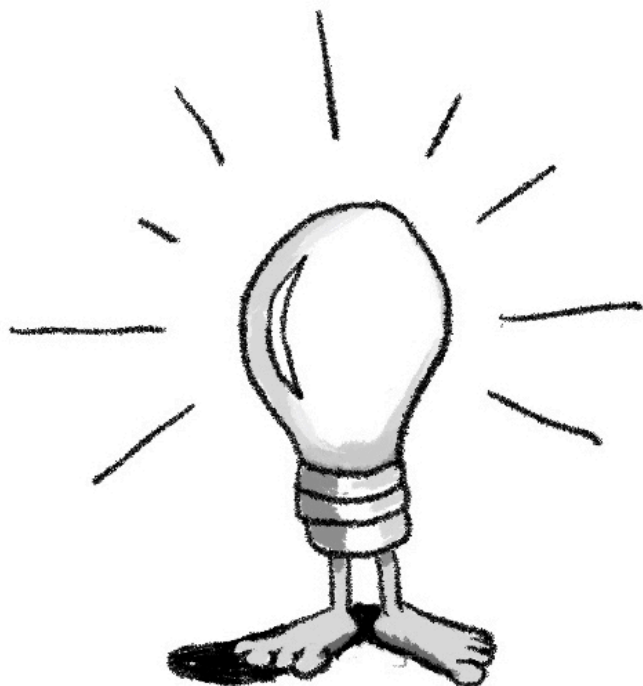
In a digital world where everything is searchable (and knowledge depends on how good your search terms are), this book is not looking to teach you everything. There are many resources out there that do a much deeper dive on every topic broached here.

However, this text is designed to help you frame your questions and to give you a vocabulary that will help you find answers. It is designed to provide you with a set of tools to help you express yourself to the best of your ability.

That expression, both visual and aural, requires an understanding of the artistic and technical processes of filmmaking. It is those methods that we aim to explore, because if you understand the approaches at work, you can figure out how to say everything you want to say.

Wherever you live, whoever you are, whatever resources you have available to you, you can say something important with this medium. The key is to figure out how you want to say it.

Trust your instincts. Be inquisitive. Pursue knowledge. Seek answers.



SPOILERS AHEAD

In this chapter you will learn:

- What the creative process is.
- How to define content and form.
- What the various categories of filmmaking are.

Reading the following chapters will forever change the way you perceive film, television, and all other media you consume.

Proceed with caution!



Up until now, you have been a member of the general movie/television/streaming audience. You have sat comfortably in the dark, enjoying the spectacle on the screen and passively accepting its magic.

As you have watched, you have felt a myriad of emotions. Hope, longing, dread, delight, et cetera, et cetera, et cetera.

All of these emotions have been elicited by the images on the screen and the sounds accompanying them, neither of which required anything of you but to watch and listen.

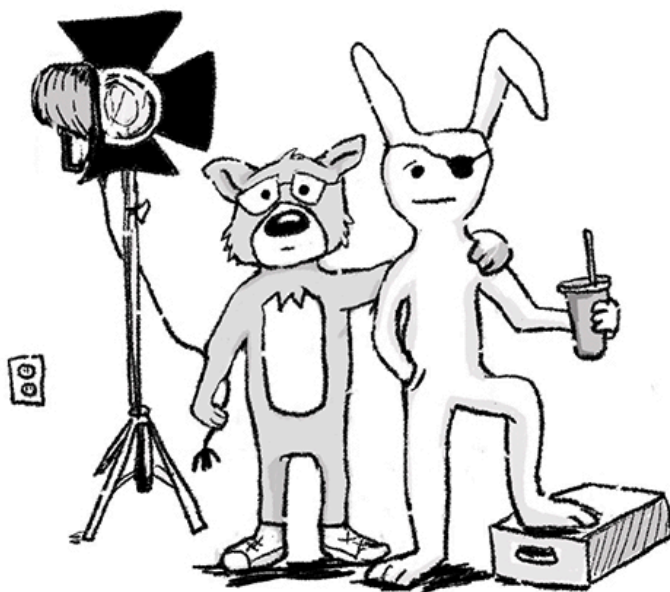
But have you ever wondered how it all works?



As an artist, you must understand the medium with which you are creating. To do that, you must first deconstruct it into its parts. Then, by understanding the individual pieces, you will be able to use them effectively.

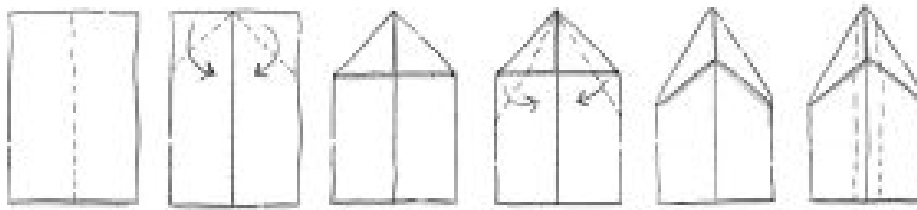
Have you ever taken a clock apart to see how it works? This is precisely what we are going to do.

By deconstructing the medium of filmmaking, you will discover the secrets that make it work, the clever methods through which emotion is created, and how you can adopt those methods to say something powerful to others.



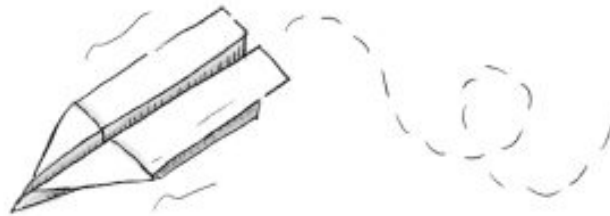
The Creative Process

How do you make something? Whether you are making a paper plane, a fried egg, or something much more complex, you are most likely following a process.



When you make a film, or any other work of art, that process is not just technical—it's also creative.

Understanding the creative process is as essential as knowing the technical steps needed to build whatever you have dreamed up.



At the heart of the creative process lies the ability to ask questions about the world around you. How does it impact you? What is your unique perspective on it? How do you want to share that perspective?

Answering these questions leads you on a journey of creation.

The creator is you.



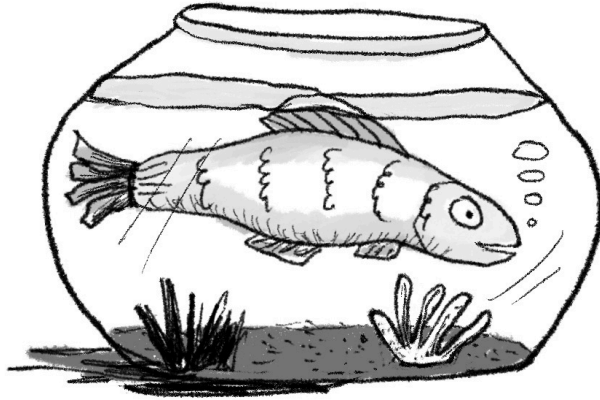
So, what do you have to say? This question has a double meaning. Not only does it ask what resides in you that you *could* share with the world, but also what you *must* share with the world:

- What story must you tell?
- What emotion must you share?

You have a unique and singular point of view. Your life experience is unique to you, and you know the details of that experience better than anyone. The emotions you feel, however, are shared by all.

Emotion is universal. Point of view is unique.

Your filmmaking should reflect your unique point of view and convey emotion that can be shared with everyone.



Content Versus Form

You gain an understanding of things by asking questions. The more questions you ask, the more questions you will discover you need the answers to. Sometimes, just understanding what questions you need to ask is what matters most. The questions you ask will ultimately define the answer you get.

WHAT? HOW? WHO?

Let's ask a significant question:

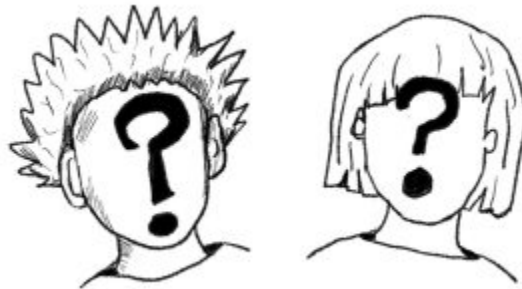
What is something really important to you?

Perhaps the more interesting question is:

Why is this important to you?

One more question:

What would you want to convey to others about what's important to you?



Let's say that skydiving, specifically octogenarian skydiving, is extremely important to you. (If you don't know what that is, take a moment to look it up.) For you, it is the ultimate expression of freedom at any age and a reminder that life must be lived to the fullest. Octogenarian skydiving is so important to you that you are compelled to share your passion for it with others. Specifically, you want to share the emotion that it generates in you. How do you do this?

It's time for a distinction.

There is a difference between *what* you want to say and *how* you are going to say it. This is referred to as content versus form.

Content

The content is the “what.” Content refers to the information, subject matter, or story that you are conveying.

Form

The form is the “how.” Form refers to the way you present the story—how you visualize it.



Let’s take the idea of octogenarian skydivers. The content is the message you want to convey (e.g., freedom) and the story you weave in order to express it. In contrast, every decision you make about the look of your project, from the lighting and camera work to the editing and sound design, is all part of your form. Having a good understanding of what you want to say will invariably help you make decisions about how you want to say it.

Let’s take stock. So far, we have discussed *what* you have to say and *how* you are going to say it. But we’re missing a third piece of the puzzle: *Whom* are you going to say it to?

Remember that while you sometimes create purely for your own enjoyment, things get really interesting when you want to share your ideas with others.

With whom are you sharing?

An audience.

Who is your audience?

Knowing this will help inform the decisions you make as you realize your idea.



Are you making a piece as a birthday gift for your grandmother? Is it for the eyes of a small group of friends? How about the local art scene? What about all children between the ages of 12 and 14 living in a suburb of Omaha, Nebraska? Or is it just for you?

Which element goes where? Drag the text to the right box. Remember, content is the what. Form is the how. Audience is the who.



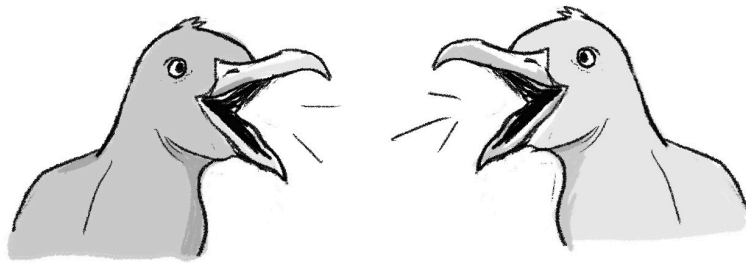
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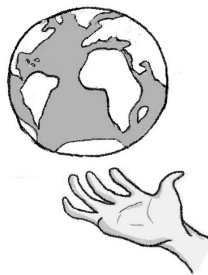
At times you may find that one of these questions is easier to answer than the others, but that's all part of the process. Keep working—the answers are within reach.

The Medium

Sharing experiences is a very human thing. Human beings are social creatures, and sharing information about the world and our feelings about it is baked into who we are as a species.



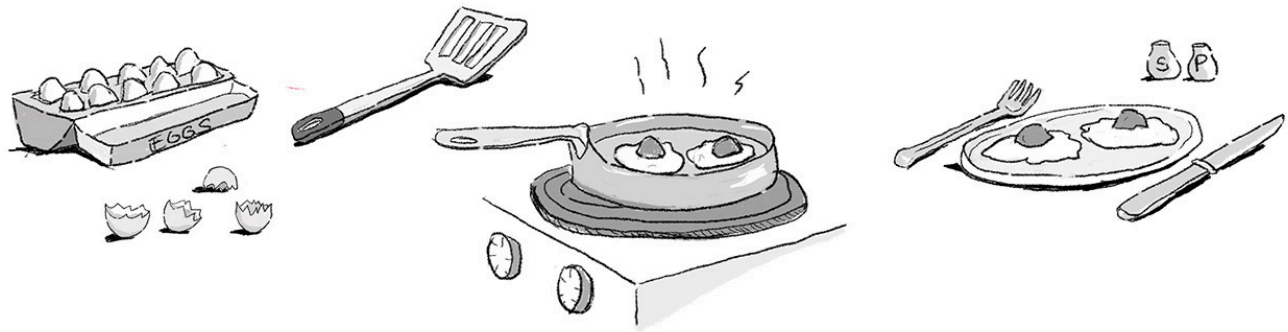
We tell stories to each other for the benefit of the group. It is a fundamental way in which we make sense of the world around us and convey meaning to one another.



Story

A story is an account of connected events, whether real or fictitious, that creates meaning and an emotional impact. Stories can be told orally, visually, or through performance, music, dance, or other forms of communication. Stories convey a point of view and have an underlying message or moral. There are many different ways you can tell stories, with each medium tackling a subject in a slightly different way.

One thing that all approaches to storytelling have in common is that there is a clearly defined beginning, middle, and end.



As with everything else, asking questions is a good way to make sense of it all:

- What are the elements of your story?
- How do you pull all the pieces together?
- Who is your audience, and how do you engage them with your story?

WHAT? HOW? WHO?

This may appear a little daunting, so let's start with something simple.

Here are three basic categories of filmmaking for you to consider. Each category follows a set of guidelines that will determine how you approach your film.

Avant-Garde

This is an experimental approach to filmmaking that intentionally breaks conventional narrative and visual rules to challenge an audience's perceptions.

Nonfiction

This is the portrayal of real people or events and is often referred to as "documentary."

Fiction

This is the fictional portrayal of invented characters and events.

One can apply each of these approaches to the same story. This will inevitably change how that story is conveyed and how the audience interacts with it.

Note: These approaches are not mutually exclusive. Avant-garde technique can find its way into nonfiction or fiction filmmaking as easily as nonfiction technique can show up in fiction or avant-garde films. The same is true for fiction filmmaking technique.



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<https://lmu.pressbooks.pub/filmmaking/?p=1248#h5p-55>

Student Perspectives – Storytelling

Keisha Davis on figuring out which story to tell:



“When it was time to decide what my thesis film would be, my process was very simple: I considered what story was banging the loudest on my chest, declaring that it should be told, and then I factored in what would be attainable with my budget, time constraints, and resources.

From there, this striking story about my grandmother losing her mother young and having to fend for herself, along with the fact that my mother also lost her mother relatively young, began to develop. *Burnt Roux* took ten drafts to get just right, but the shooting process was the easiest and most magical I could ask for. I was blessed with an amazing location in St. Bernard, Louisiana, and a great local crew and talent.

Being on location (which in this case meant being home) really helped bring this story to life. We were in a secluded area and had the entire house and property to ourselves. I had a lot of quiet time in the morning to think and think again about my shots and put myself in Amelia’s shoes.

It led to some really powerful and beautiful moments in this film that I’m still very proud of.”

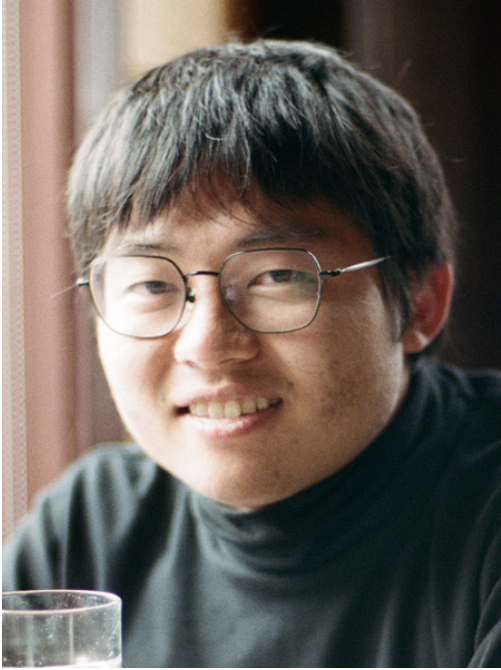
- Film Title: *Burnt Roux*
- Logline: In 1968 rural Louisiana, a young activist gets a disturbing interruption as she struggles to finish her speech and make the perfect roux before leaving for her first protest.



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Tapio Tokunaga on tackling the same subject matter in two different films:



“1446, a three-minute documentary film about my experience during the 3.11 Earthquake in Japan, was one of the first films I directed at film school. In it, I tackled the fragility of life with a simple narration of what happened to me and my family members on March 11th, 2011. My goal was to demonstrate how vulnerable our “ordinary” lives are and how precious spending time with those who you love is. Normally, a talking head of me with some B-rolls of the actual footage of the earthquakes would have been a go-to method for making this kind of documentary, but I figured out that would not be enough to express the emotion I felt on a day that traumatized me. Due to the covid restrictions that at the time had me stuck alone in Japan (and some amazing feedback in class), I came up with a bold idea — I did not use any actual footage of the earthquake but instead employed

LEGO blocks to re-create the experience and destruction. The child-like LEGO blocks, often associated with happy memories, contrasts with the heaviness of the film’s topic to accentuate the traumatizing fear during the earthquake. The lack of actual footage stimulated the imagination of the audiences and invited them into the raw emotional experience more deeply. The use of slow-motion, contrasting the stop motion often associated with LEGO movies, also “froze” the emotional momentum to soak audiences in this extreme experience. This creative process pushed me to challenge my creativity and taught me the value of juxtaposition and metaphor.

My 15-minute senior capstone film, MINIFIG, also tackled a similar topic of familial bond and loss, based on my own experience. Aside from the obvious difference in genre and duration of the film, my first question was very similar to 1446 — how do I maximize the emotional experience in the story? Inspired by 1990s-2000s anime films that I grew up with, I decided to use a juxtaposition of happy childhood memories and realistic moments, intertwining timelines and fantastical elements, and again featured LEGO as a key prop of the narrative, like 1446. The biggest difference from 1446, however, was how collaborative the creative process was for MINIFIG. The most valuable lesson I learned from MINIFIG was to count on, and believe in, my crew and cast members. As a director, I was certainly responsible for the final product, but it was crucial not to dictate every single creative choice. I invited my cast and crew members, producers, DP, PD, and sound designers into the early stage of the screenwriting and pre-production to have everyone dive into the emotional journey in the story. While 1446 was certainly directed by and 99% made by myself in all aspects, MINIFIG is not just my film but our film. The immense collaborations and integration of different creative ideas gave MINIFIG a huge emotional impact on audiences, signified by the sobs of most of the attendees at my screening.”

- Website: www.tapio-tokunaga.com
- Film Title: *I446*
- Logline: A documentary short film that examines the fragility of life against the backdrop of the Fukushima earthquake disaster.
- Password: shindo7



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- Film Title: *MINIFIG*
- Logline: Haunted by his life changing familial loss, a boy ventures into escapist childhood memories while chasing his missing, cherished LEGO minifigure.
- Password: suomi-perhe



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CINEMATIC SPACE

In this chapter you will learn:

- What cinematic space is.
- How the illusion of motion pictures is created.
- What the essential tools of filmmaking are.

When you think of space, what comes to mind?

Perhaps you envision a cold, dark void and alien planets. Or maybe you see room to stretch out in, a place to breathe and create and make something new.



Cinematic space is where every film lives.

It's a place where you decide the rules, and you control what happens.

It is a space where a person can hear the thoughts of the people around them. It is a space that allows two people to be emotionally tied even though they are separated by tremendous physical distance. It is a space that allows a character to step through a door at home and find themselves in the middle of the Gobi Desert.



Cinema is not reality. It is a manufactured construct, a simulacrum, but one that an audience willingly engages with.

Your job as a filmmaker is to manipulate the cinematic space in the way that best fits the story you are telling.

You will do this through the manipulation of every element of filmmaking, including where you put your camera, how you fill your frame to create shots, and how you edit your shots together. All this and more is a manipulation of the cinematic space.

Keep reading to learn how!

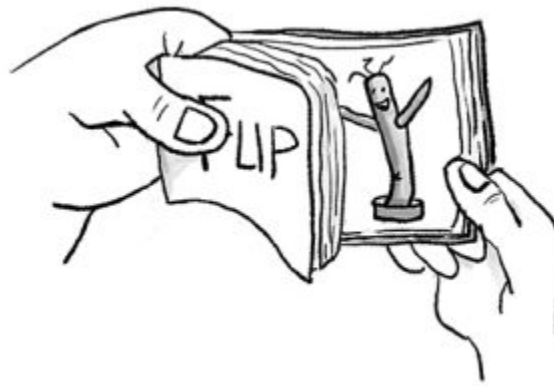
The Illusion

When you watch a movie, a television show, or a video online, does the image move?

Despite what your brain is telling you, the answer is “no.” All you are seeing is light.

So why do you perceive this as movement?

Consider how a flipbook works: A series of images is presented to you in rapid succession. Your brain connects the individual stills to create an illusion of movement.

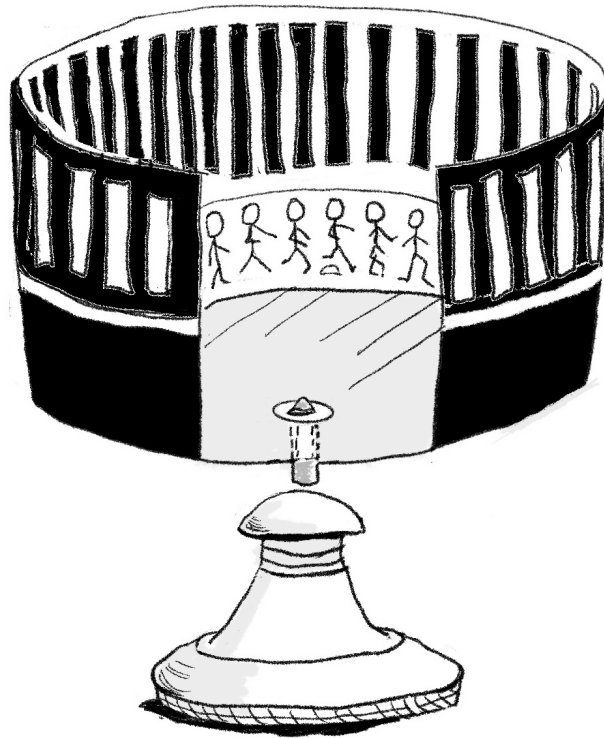


Once again, your brain is making order out of chaos, in this case using a mechanism referred to as **persistence of vision**.

Each image is presented for a brief moment, disappears, and is replaced by a subsequent image. The brain retains the memory of each image slightly longer than the eyes see it. As a result, the brain connects all the images into a seemingly moving whole.

The motion picture camera utilizes this mechanism by recording many frames per second. When these images are projected on a movie screen, television screen, or computer monitor, we perceive movement much like with a flipbook.

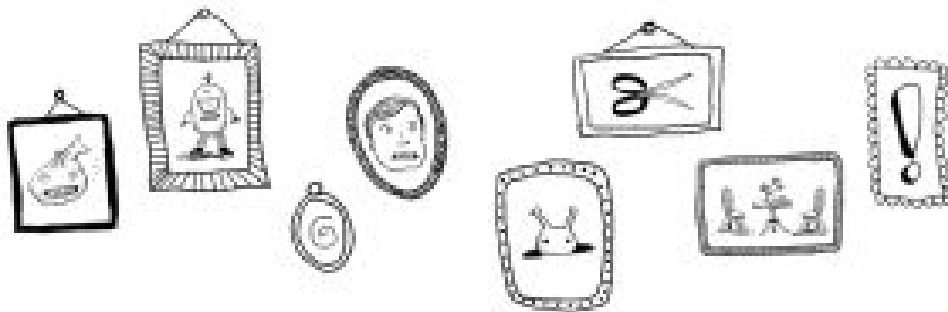
The number the individual frames and the speed at which they are recorded and played back is known as the **frame rate**. This is measured in **frames per second**, or FPS. Many different frame rates exist, and their functions and uses have evolved over time. In general, the higher the frame rate (and playback), the smoother the image.



Note: The eye must see a minimum of 12 frames per second (fps) for persistence of vision to work effectively. The higher the frame rate, the more fluid the illusion of movement.

What is a **frame**?

It is the box that serves as your canvas and within which you create windows into other worlds. All film and video images exist inside a frame.



See the frame below? Look at it a little closer. Move the slider below the image to magnify it.



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<https://lmu.pressbooks.pub/filmmaking/?p=560#h5p-19>

The closer you get to the image, the more it starts to break up, until all you are looking at is a series of various colored dots. Move further away, and the dots resolve themselves back into an image.

These dots are referred to as **pixels**.

That we can perceive a collection of pixels as an image is thanks to a mechanism in our brains called **brain reassembly**. This is the brain's way of making order out of chaos—a way of turning seemingly random pixels into patterns.



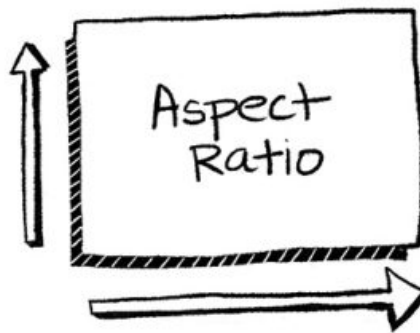
At which point can you tell what the following image is? Move the slider below the image to resolve the pixels.



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<https://lmu.pressbooks.pub/filmmaking/?p=560#h5p-20>

The shape of the frame is always a box, but it can have different dimensions. Sometimes it is more of a square, and sometimes it is more of an elongated rectangle. This is the frame's **aspect ratio**, and it affects how the image within is presented and influences how it is perceived. Aspect ratio is calculated as a ratio of width to height, ie. Width:Height



How does a different aspect ratio affect the audience's perception of the image? Move the slider below the following image to explore different aspect ratios.



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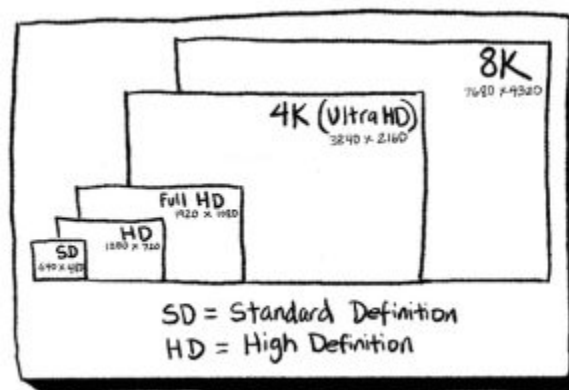
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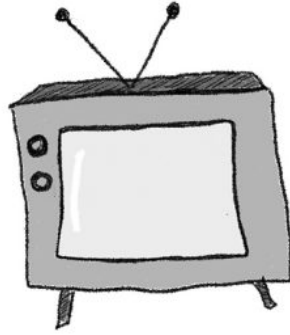
Not all images are created equal. Depending on the number of pixels that form the image, that image will have more or less detail in it.

In video, pixels cluster together in lines of resolution. The more lines of pixels, the higher the quality of the image. Resolution is the number of horizontal lines that make up each frame.

Video formats vary greatly in quality depending on the number of lines of resolution that they can store.



Note: Film is a photographic medium that requires chemical processing to produce a frame. Instead of pixels, film is comprised of silver halide crystals that react to exposure to light. Film formats vary depending on how large the film gauge is. The larger the gauge, the more silver halide crystals can fit on each frame, resulting in more image detail.



What you put in the frame and how you put it there are questions that you will be answering in perpetuity. Every time you embark on a new project, you will ask yourself what to show and how to show it. And it all sits neatly (or sometimes not so neatly) inside the frame.

The Toolbox

Tools have been key to the survival of our species. Tools to make fire. Tools to grow food. Tools to express complex ideas that engender progress and growth.

We invent. We create. And as a result, we connect with one another.



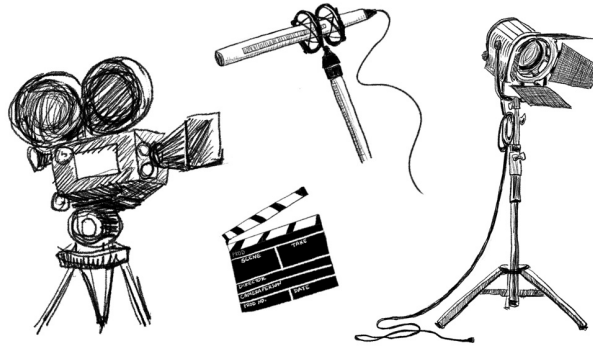
Filmmaking, like all art forms, uses a combination of tools and techniques. The essential tools of filmmaking are those that enable you to manipulate images and sound.

Most likely, you can think of at least three:

1. a [camera](#)
2. a [light](#)
3. a [microphone](#)

You might also be thinking, what about [shots](#)? What about [editing](#)? Are those tools too?

The answer is a resounding “yes!”



There are dozens, hundreds, even thousands of tools that are used to bring our ideas to the screen. Multitudes of toys that manipulate what we see and hear in innovative and compelling ways.

However, you must remember to balance an appreciation of these toys with a clear sense of what you want to say. After all, the tools are there to serve the vision, and no more. Understanding how these tools work will give you ultimate control over the stories you plan to share.

In truth, filmmaking borrows from all other art forms, from theatre to dance to music and beyond. It lifts ideas from engineering and architecture and poetry and painting. Thanks to generations of scientists, inventors, engineers, artists, entrepreneurs, and artisans, you have access to many tools with which to actualize the magic in your head.

Use any and all tools available to you. You are a communicator and an innovator, a technician and an artist. To be a filmmaker, you must understand the tools of your craft.

Without tools, you cannot create.



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<https://lmu.pressbooks.pub/filmmaking/?p=1271#h5p-40>



Student Perspectives – Cinematic Space

Dakota Fitzsimmons on visualizing what's at stake:



“The most important thing that I learned and that I take with me into my artistic practice is that we have to be visually transformative with our stories. Take loneliness, for example. It’s not enough for a character to be alone in a scene or to look sad in a frame. You have to place them in the world of the film that makes them alone. In the case of *Outskirted*, I had to create a world in which her heart and soul and feelings are on screen and not buried solely in acting, hence making her a late-night DJ. It’s not simply enough to show someone being lonely/depressed/sad/joyful. You have to visualize that deeply rooted feeling and reality.

Transforming the main obstacle or feeling that your character is grappling with into something physical will allow your audience to have buy-in that they may not have inherently had available to them at the start. In *Outskirted*, visualizing Jo’s need to belong in the form of an alien abduction allows Jo the opportunity for connection, one that she is deeply missing. It also allows the audience to see a version of what this connection feels like in an unexpected

way. Visualizing Jo’s feelings in this manner makes it possible to not only tell more diverse and widely impactful stories, but allows me to create worlds that distill what I’m feeling and trying to say into something that can be broadly understood through visual storytelling.”

- **Film Title:** *Outskirted*
- **Logline:** A deeply lonely late-night DJ is abducted by an alien and must decide if she wants to stay on Earth.

<https://vimeo.com/109735234?share=copy>



CAMERA

In this chapter you will learn:

- How a camera functions, including its various parts.
- How to control focus and depth of field.
- How lenses work and how they affect the image.
- What color light is.

Consider the experience of watching a stage play from the back of the theater.

Have you ever wished you could crawl onto the stage and move around the actors? What if you could see inside their heads? What if you could become the characters themselves?

Well, with a camera, you can create that experience. And it all depends on how you shoot your project.

Unlike theatre, which is restricted to a wide shot in one location, looking in a single direction, the camera allows you to move anywhere you like. You get to design each shot from any perspective you want. What you place inside the frame or decide to leave out of the frame will determine the cinematic space you create.

A camera allows you freedom to tell a story any way you like.



So, how does it all work?

The human body has essential components that enable us to see the world and interpret what we see in a way that makes sense. Each of these basic components also exists in the camera.

Head

Our head contains all the parts that enable us to see.

In the camera, this is called the **light-tight box**. Like our heads, this is the housing where the image is captured. It must be “light tight” to prevent light from entering it other than from one direction.

Eyes

The human eye focuses light with the help of a lens and allows it to enter the head through an iris. Depending on the amount of light present, the iris either expands or contracts. This lets in just the right amount of light in order for us to see.

A camera works in exactly the same way.

First, a camera needs a **lens**—a curved piece of glass or plastic that focuses light into it. This is the mechanism that allows light to enter the camera housing.

Inside the lens, much like inside the eye, is an **iris**, or **aperture**, which controls how much light is let into the box. The amount of light that enters the box is referred to as **exposure**.

Inside the box, the light is separated by a **beam splitter** into the three primary colors: red, green, and blue (RGB). This is similar to what happens in the retina of our eye.

Brain

Our brain processes the signals sent to it.

In the camera, this function is performed by the **image processing sensor**. This “brain” converts the beams of light into digital information (binary code).

The camera is essentially a big electronic head with a lens for eyes and a computer chip for a brain. But understanding its parts is the first step toward operating it.



Nuts and Bolts

We're going to get a little technical for a moment, so take a deep breath.



All cameras work the same way, but the quality of the image they capture will vary greatly depending on the quality of the individual components. What follows is an explanation of some of those components.

Remember, the tools used in filmmaking require some understanding, and the more you understand about these tools, the better you will be able to use them.

So, let's dive in and ask some questions about the camera. Specifically, let's look at the following concepts:



- [image sensor](#)
- [recording format](#)
- [storage](#)
- [lens](#)
- [audio](#)
- [manual settings](#)



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This may seem like a lot to remember, but in time, it will all become second nature. After all, you're learning an entirely new language. It takes time to become fluent, so be patient with yourself.



B-FLAT

Filmmaking is both a technical endeavor and a creative one, and the two are inextricably linked to one another. Understanding how the technical aspects impact the creative and vice versa means you will have greater command over the medium.

Let's look a little closer at some of the creative and technical aspects that you will be contending with every time you pick up a camera.

There is a little acronym that reminds us how our technical decisions inform our creative choices before we start the camera rolling.

Let's dive in and ask some questions about the camera. Specifically, let's look at the following concepts:

- B: [balance](#)
- F: [focus](#)
- L: [lens](#)
- A: [aperture](#)
- T: [temperature](#)

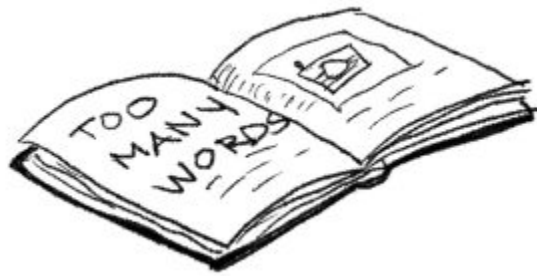
Using B-FLAT before every shot reminds you to pause and ask, "Have I made the strongest creative choices for this moment?" It is a constant reminder to double-check the decisions you have made (or have failed to make!).

Use B-FLAT, and your audience will thank you.



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B-FLAT is there to help you make decisions. These decisions are sometimes technical, but they are

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always creative. And at the heart of every decision lies the question: What do you want your audience to feel?

LIGHT

In this chapter you will learn:

- How light affects emotion.
- Different ways to control light.
- What the basics of a three-point lighting setup are.

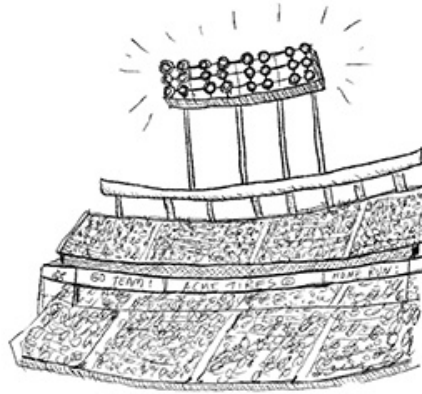
How does light influence and impact us?



The simple answer is that it enables us to see. It enters our eyes, where it is processed into information that is sent to our brains. As a result, we have a unique sense that enables us to interact with the world around us visually, to great advantage.

However, light also affects how we feel.

Think of a cloud-covered morning in a city, candles at a romantic dinner, or the glare of stadium lighting in the middle of a sporting event.



Every moment of our day is impacted by light in ways that are far more complex than simply enabling us to see.

Consider the following images. How does what you feel change depending on how the light is used?



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Creative Control

Light is something to be sculpted and manipulated according to the emotional needs of your project. Consider the following emotions:

- fear
- relief
- suspicion
- joy

How might you use light to convey them?
There is no right answer.



Let's use the emotion of fear as an example. You might create abject terror by plunging your scene into the darkest shadows and obscuring what the audience can see. However, depending on the type of story you are telling, it is also conceivable that bright, piercing light might be more effective.

As with any aspect of filmmaking, if the results work, then that is all that matters.

There are four distinct ways in which you can control light.

Quality

The quality of light can vary. Think about the light on a sunny afternoon with no clouds in the sky. Compare that to another day in which the clouds have rolled in and hidden the sun. In what ways does the light coming from the same source change?

1. Direct light has a clear and uninterrupted path from its source. It is notable for casting defined shadows. This sort of light also has a very concentrated spread.
2. Diffused light is scattered and soft, a result of something obscuring and diffusing the source. It is notable for its lack of defined shadows and its even distribution across a subject. It is sometimes referred to as "soft" light.

If you think back to our sunny and cloudy days, what sort of light does each cast?

Direction

Have you ever held a flashlight under your chin to tell a scary story? Why did you do this? What makes the direction of this light inherently creepy?

Changing the direction of a light changes the audience's perception of the image.

How does your subject matter look if it is lit from the front? How about from the side? From the back? Below? Above?

Intensity

The intensity or amount of light changes depending on its source.

Consider the amount of light emitted by a stadium spotlight. Compare that to the nightlight by your bed. Compare that to the sun.

Each light source generates a different intensity, which can be manipulated.

You can change the intensity of a light source in several ways.

- Decrease or increase the intensity. This might be done by using a dimmer or switching out a bulb with a lower or higher wattage. This is not something you can do with the sun, for obvious reasons.
- Place something in front of the light to cut the intensity. This may involve using various grip equipment or a neutral density filter. Either way, you are placing a light-cutting element between the light source and the image processor.
- Move the light closer to or farther away from your subject.
- Move the subject closer to or farther away from your light source.

This is a good time to revisit the subject of [f-stops](#).

As you may recall, the f-stop on your camera is an indication of the size of the aperture. It controls how much light is hitting the image processor.

Depending on the intensity of your light source, you will need to adjust your f-stop to obtain the correct exposure. Furthermore, depending on the depth of field you are hoping to achieve, you may need to adjust the intensity of the light to achieve the required f-stop.

The f-stop you use is a creative decision. Manipulate the intensity of the light source to match your f-stop goal.

Color

What color is light? It all depends on how you and the camera perceive it. Remember, it's a matter of [color temperature](#).

The simplest way to control the color of a light is to put something in front of it. Use colored gels to rapidly change the color temperature of your light source.

NOTE: Be very careful when you put anything in front of a light. If using gels, only use special film gels that are designed to withstand the heat generated by the light source. Using something else can cause a fire!

Different colors can be used to great impact in the same frame. Color can be one of the ways in which you can create a unique style and look for your project.

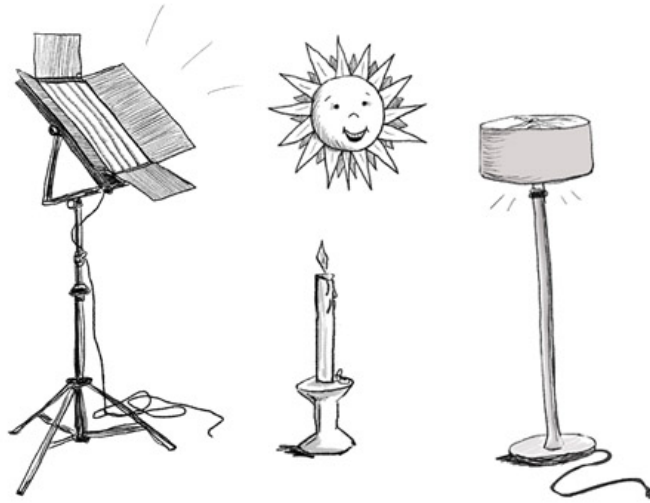
There is no need to be “realistic” with your use of color. Find ways to make your color

represent different emotional states. This can be an excellent way to telegraph ideas to an audience.

You don't need fancy equipment to manipulate light. Sometimes it's as simple as deciding if the sun is in front of the subject or behind it.

Film sets have a whole department dedicated to rigging and manipulating light—the grip and electric department—and they use a large range of equipment to do so. This equipment includes C-stands, flags, silks, nets, clamps, and apple boxes. The list of clever ways to manipulate light is endless, and the best way to learn is to work on a set and see the gear in action.

Use whatever you have at your disposal, but do so with intent.



Three-Point Lighting

Three-point lighting is the most traditional approach to lighting and is a solid starting point. This system will ensure balanced illumination and enhanced visual detail.

Key

This is the light by which we set our exposure. Its placement is usually motivated by an on-screen source of lighting (a window, desk lamp, candle, etc.).



Fill

This is a softer, more diffused source that fills in the shadows. This light is used to compensate for the limited exposure range of the camera.



Back

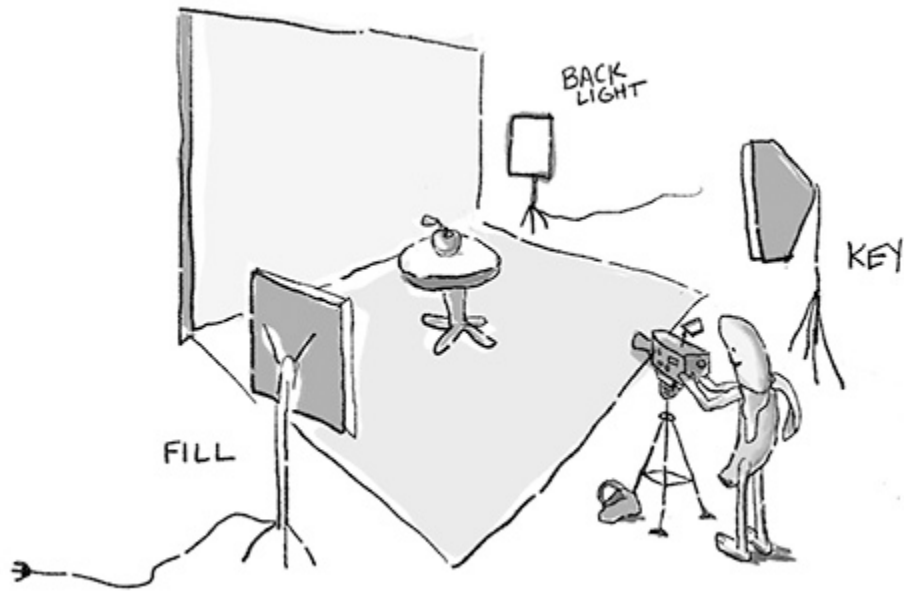
This light is used to create separation between our subject and the background.



Now look at how they all work together. Move the slider to see the full effect.



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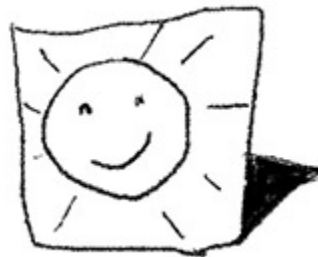
There are a couple of other lights to consider:

- **Eye light** is the glint of light that shows up in a person's eyeball and brings that person's eyes to life. Without this, characters may appear lifeless.
- **Background lighting** will add texture to our shot and enhance separation.
How does using a different colored background enhance your shot?

You can use this basic approach when considering all types of lighting situations, even when working outdoors in the sun. In that situation, you might ask yourself whether you want to use the sun as a key light, fill, or back light.

The sun could be any of these, depending on whether it is striking the subject matter directly, from behind, or being bounced in with a bounce board or reflector.

Who says you can't control the sun?



Student Perspectives - Light

Matthew Cheung on lighting for the outdoors:



“Regardless of whether you’re filming exterior or interior scenes, I believe it’s essential to keep lighting motivated by the story and setting. Lighting in outdoor environments requires careful planning to feel both natural and intentional. Light should come from the direction of the sun. During preproduction on one of my projects, I tracked the sun’s position throughout the day so we could schedule shots with the sun consistently behind our subjects. This not only separated them from the background and avoided unwanted crew shadows, but also reduced our reliance on diffusion, which can sometimes make sunlight look artificial when overused.

When planning for my music video *Butterflies x Who Am I?*, I used an app called Sun Tracker to know exactly where the sun would be at every hour of the day. This allowed me to maintain a consistent backlit look throughout the shoot, avoiding harsh front lighting, which can be unflattering on people’s faces. During production, it’s also important to choose bounces and lights that feel natural within the environment. While filming *To Sea*, I opted for unbleached muslin bounces to better match the sandy beach location. Unlike ultrabounces, which reflect a harsher, colder white light, unbleached muslin creates a softer, warmer glow that feels more organic and location appropriate. (It’s essentially a soft, off-white fabric that acts like a natural reflector.)“

- Website: <https://www.matthewtcheung.com/>



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<https://vimeo.com/1095750479/d99b47ff77>

SOUND

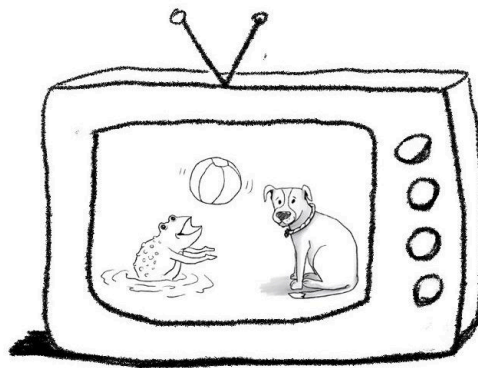
In this chapter you will learn:

- What sound is.
- How microphones function.
- Aspects of Production and Postproduction Sound.

Film is both an aural and a visual experience. However, if the visuals constitute 50 percent of that experience, sound might be said to equal 60 percent. The math may not make sense, but if a film doesn't sound right, the visuals won't work either.

Consider this: As you move through the world, you are only ever able to see what is directly in front of you. This limits you to a visual perspective of about 180 degrees. In contrast, your aural perception of the world isn't subject to such limits. You hear not only everything that is in front of and behind you, but also everything that is above and below you.

If you can translate that onto the screen, you are guaranteed to create a rich and believable experience for the audience.



This happens in two steps.

Production Sound

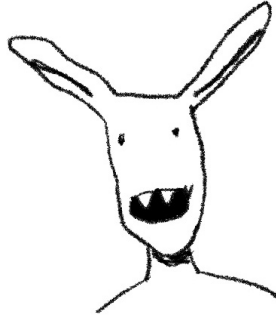
This is the sound that is recorded alongside the picture.

Postproduction Sound

This includes all the work done during the editing phase to build a believable soundscape.

As much as a picture is designed to create emotion, it is the sound that underscores every emotional beat that you experience.

Just try turning off the sound of your favorite horror movie. What do you feel?



As with everything, it is important to understand some of the technical side of sound. Let's look at the following concepts:

- [defining sound](#)
- [measuring sound](#)
- [how microphones work](#)
- [pickup patterns](#)
- [digital sound](#)



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Production Sound

Film sets are noisy places.

The producer is talking to the director. The director is talking to the cinematographer. The cinematographer is talking to the gaffer. Lights are being moved. Dolly track is being laid. Cast members are rehearsing lines. Everyone is doing their job and making lots and lots of noise.

And then, when it's time to roll camera, everything goes quiet.



It's at this point that the production sound crew had better be ready, because recording good production sound is foundational for all the sound work that must be done later.

So, what exactly is recorded on set?

Despite how your film may wind up sounding, the goal of production sound is to record very specific elements as cleanly as possible—in other words, without any interference from background sound.

These elements include:

Dialogue

The dialogue should be as clean as possible. Special microphones are used to isolate the dialogue as much as possible from the background sound.

Wild Lines

These may include additional lines of dialogue that aren't seen on screen but should be recorded in the same setting as everything else. That way, they will match the rest of the production sound and be easier to cut into the picture believably.

Wild Sound

This includes any additional elements that are key to the location and for which it may be hard to find a sound effect later.

Room Tone

The room tone is the sound of the physical space that a scene is shot in, minus any dialogue. This is often shot at the end of a scene and calls for the cast and crew to be quiet for up to a minute.

And that's it! If the production sound crew has done their work correctly, they have provided the postproduction sound team with all the essential pieces needed to craft a believable soundscape.



Recording excellent production sound depends on the following chain of components working together effectively. The quality of your sound is only as good as the quality of each link in this chain.



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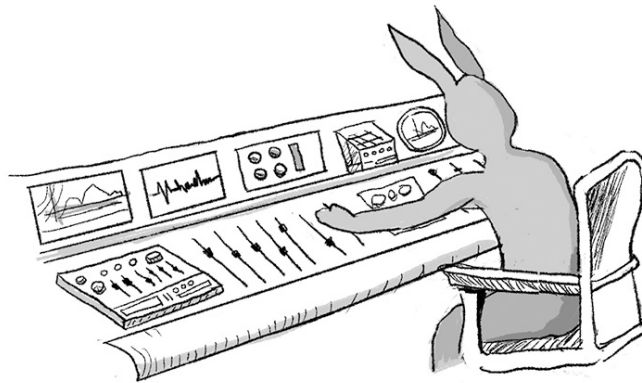
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Postproduction Sound

Nothing is quite so impactful on how you experience a film or television show as the sound that accompanies it. The way the music swells at just the right moment. The piercing cry of an anguished monster. The cheers of the crowd as the main character pushes toward their goal.

However, virtually none of what you hear existed until the picture was edited and handed over to the postproduction sound team.

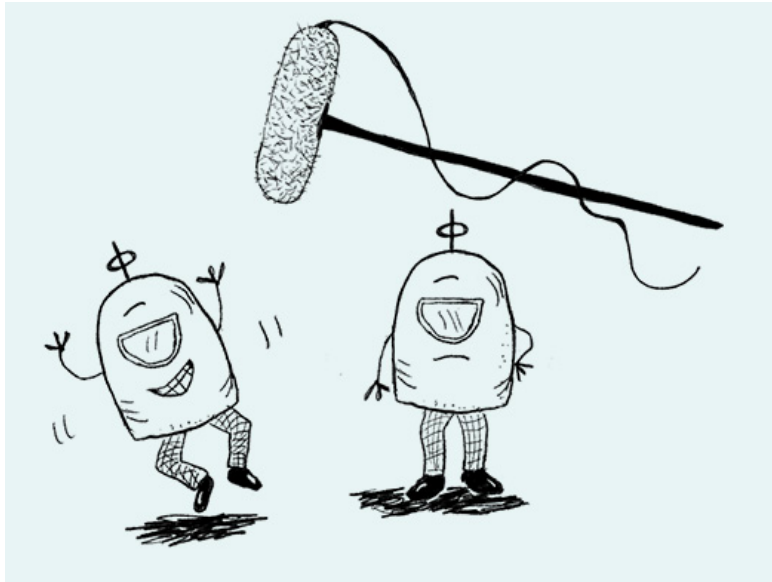


Postproduction sound is where magic truly happens.

It does this by combining a whole set of different types of sound.

Production Sound

This is the sound that is recorded on set. If your project has dialogue in it, then the focus of production sound is getting the cleanest dialogue recording possible.



Ambience/Background

These are the sounds that make up the environment in a scene, such as the background traffic, weather, and so on.



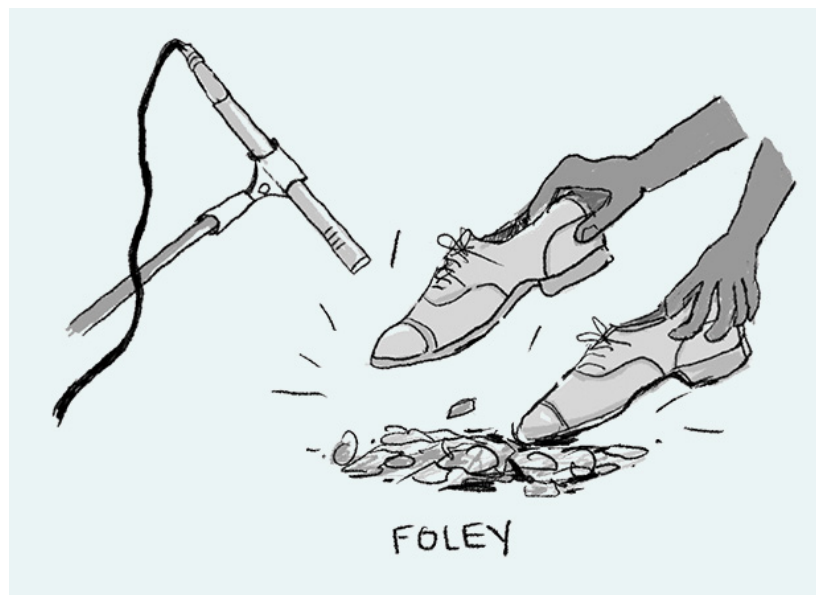
Ambient/background sounds are rarely picked up when production sound is recorded and generally need to be added later during the postproduction process.

Sound Effects

Sound effects are the sounds that are added later to underscore the action on screen. You might use readily available sounds from a sound effects library or generate your own.



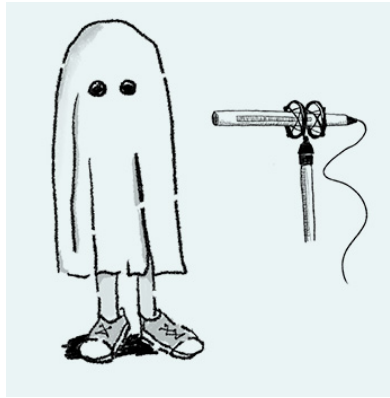
Foley effects are a unique type of sound effect. These are the sounds that are recorded specifically to the picture. These may include footsteps, items being handled, and clothes moving.



ADR/VO/Narration

These are the voice recordings that are recorded during postproduction. If the dialogue recorded during production has issues, you may need to replace it later with ADR.

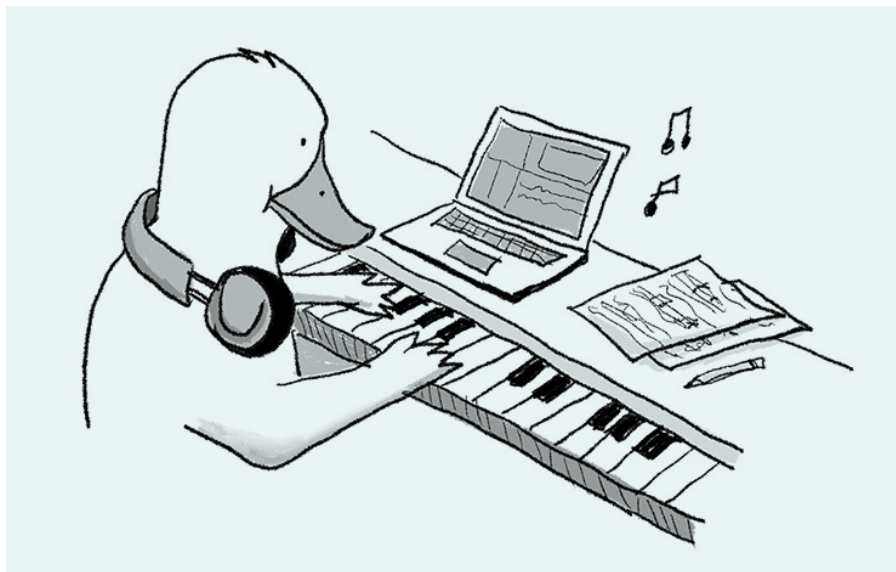
Automatic dialogue replacement (ADR; also known as looping) is the process by which an actor rerecords lines while watching the picture. They need to make sure that their performance not only stays in sync with what is on the screen but also matches the emotion of the scene.



VO stands for voice over and includes any narration that accompanies the picture where the voice is heard “over” the picture.

Music/Score

It’s hard to think of watching a film or television show without music. Music so often drives the emotion of the scene and can readily elicit strong feelings with the fewest of notes. Think about your favorite film score, and take note of the emotion that just thinking about it produces.



The score is recorded separately from the other sound editorial work and may include a full orchestra, a handful of instruments, or even none at all if the score is purely digital.

Note: Not every film needs an elaborate score. Sometimes it’s enough to have the bare minimum of music or to go without altogether. Do what is right for the film!

All of the above sounds are collected, created, edited, and mixed throughout the postproduction process and result in a finished soundtrack that accompanies your film.



This happens in different stages:

1. **Sound editorial:** Having received the locked picture from the editor, the sound work begins by cleaning up the dialogue tracks to smooth out the levels and remove unwanted sounds. Dialogue may need to be rerecorded if the production tracks are unusable.
2. **Sound design:** Effects are added from sound effects libraries or created specifically for the film. This includes Foley effects.
3. **Rerecording and final mix:** All the elements are brought together to create the final soundtrack. The final mix is often done in a room that mimics a movie theatre, thereby ensuring that the film will sound correct when it is screened by an audience.

Multiple versions of the final mix may be created for different modes of distribution. A theatrical mix is quite different from that required to stream online. Be sure you have the right mix for your screening needs.



Student Perspectives – Sound

Rhea Alsharabaty on using sound to build a believable universe:



“I leveraged sound design in order to overcome the three challenges I faced making this film. First, being a dialogue-centric comedy, it was out of my wheelhouse. Second, my set was built on a soundstage. Third, my cast included two inanimate characters: a toilet and a stool.

The rough cut I had before I started sound designing felt incomplete. Two characters were missing, the location lacked credibility, and the universe was not believable.

Sound was the key. Not only did it give the audience better access to the main character’s psyche, but it also gave voices to the toilet and the stool. Just like that, the remaining two characters were born!

To sell the absurd and playful universe I created, I exploited a wide spectrum of sound effects, from cartoonish plops to ominous rumbles, setting the tone and conveying each emotional beat. I could iterate, layering sounds as much as necessary until each moment had its desired impact.

I specifically searched for a composer who understood my vision for the film and what I perceived as the shortcomings of my rough cut. We worked closely to ensure the music drove the plot, punctuating or smoothing things out where necessary. In this way, the soundtrack was the connective tissue of the final cut.

Through this holistic soundscape, what began as a disjointed rough cut became a fully integrated world where even a toilet could steal the scene.”

- **Film Title:** *Stalling*
- **Logline:** While collecting a stool sample in a hospital bathroom, a worried woman gets some timely advice from her toilet.



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THE SHOT

In this chapter you will learn:

- What the different characteristics of a shot are.
- Fundamental compositional techniques.
- Ways to move the camera.

One talks a lot about shots in filmmaking. It is a word that is tossed around and used in almost every conversation, oftentimes incorrectly. So, what exactly is a shot? How does one define it?

A **shot**, quite simply, is an uninterrupted segment of motion picture time.

It might last a few frames or several minutes. It might incorporate elaborate movement or remain static throughout. It might encompass a panoramic vista or the intricate detail of something microscopic.

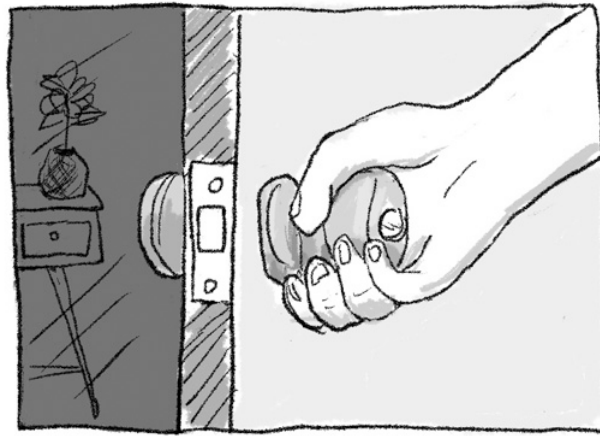


A powerful shot never simply shows something. Instead, it comments on what it shows in creative and compelling ways. A good shot always elicits a strong emotional response to its content.

How you use shots to make commentary on your content can be broken down into four aspects:

- size
- composition
- angle
- movement

It is up to you to decide how to incorporate each of these four aspects into your shot design. Doing so intentionally will help you convey your message that much more powerfully. This is key to your visual storytelling.



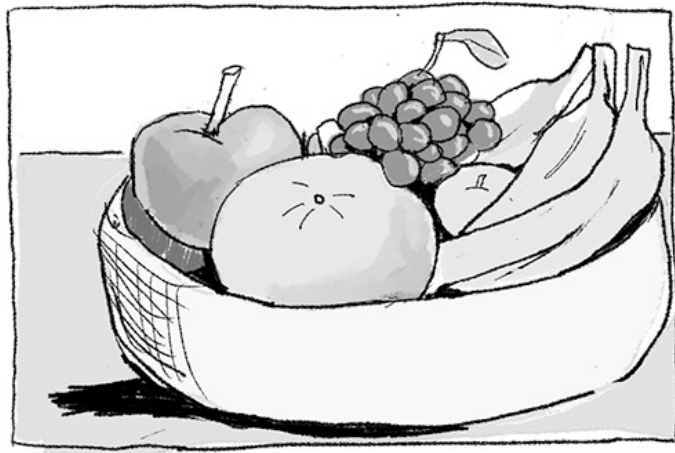
Note: A shot is not to be confused with a take. If a shot is an uninterrupted segment of motion picture time, a **take** is an individual version of a shot. Multiple takes are frequently filmed for the same shot.

Shot Size

The size of your shot has a tremendous impact on how your audience interprets the image in the frame. It can carry great emotional weight as well as affect how much information the audience receives.

Are you striving to create meaningful intimacy? Do you want to call attention to a particular element or hide it altogether? Do you want to draw your audience in or alienate them?

What you do with your shot size will decide this and much more.



From a purely technical standpoint, shot size determines how much of the scene is shown to the audience. It is always relative to the subject matter.

The basic shot sizes are:

- XCU: extreme close up
- CU: close up
- MS: medium shot
- WS: wide shot
- XWS: extreme wide shot

Note: A wide shot can also be referred to as a long shot.

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These shot sizes describe shots in relation to distance—in other words, the proximity of the audience to the subject matter.

Bear in mind that there is no standard shot size. It is always relative to the subject matter.

For example, a wide shot of two dinosaurs on a mountaintop will look very different from a wide shot of two cockroaches on a leaf.



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Describing shot sizes in relation to distance from subject matter may not always be enough information to convey what is included in the shot. To help with this, we can also use a reference to the actual subject itself, describing how we frame the body (assuming the subject is a person). We can also describe the physical relationships among people and objects.

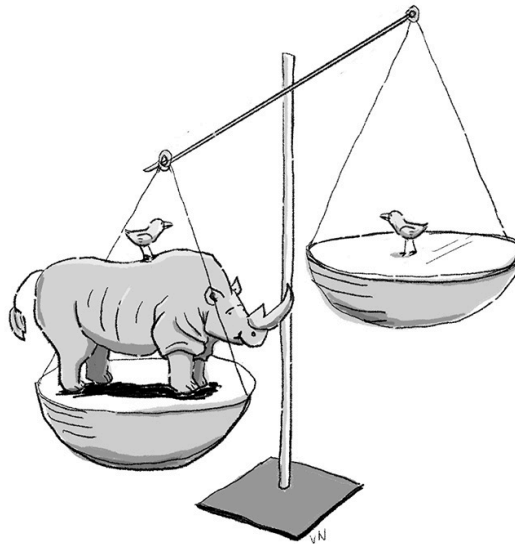
Ways to describe shot size in relation to a person include the following:

- head and shoulders
- full
- two shot, three shot, and so on
- bust
- waist
- cowboy
- over the shoulder (OTS)
- point of view (POV)
- body part, such as feet, hands, eyes, and so on

Note: It is vital to note that shot sizes are not a gauge of the proximity of the camera to the subject. Different lens choices give the impression of different distances, but one can just as easily do a close-up with a wide-angle lens as with a telephoto lens. Your shot size should always be a creative decision, not simply a function of the equipment itself.

Composition

You are standing in front of a canvas. In your mind's eye is a feeling, an idea, or an emotion. How do you show it?



For millennia, artists have pondered this question. Ultimately, every artist must find their own solutions, but there are many techniques that have been developed to facilitate this work.

It all begins with directing the eyes of the audience.

After all, you are controlling an emotional experience, and if the audience doesn't know where to look, they are not going to experience the image as you intend.

To do this, you need an understanding of how to arrange visual elements within a frame. In other words, you need to understand **composition**, or the arrangement of elements in the frame.

Look at the following images and ask yourself where your eye goes.



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Directing the eyes of the audience is done consciously to manipulate the emotional response.

But how is it done?

An emotionally strong composition starts with building tension. The primary way to do this is to use **contrast** within the frame, specifically, juxtaposing opposing visual elements.

This might involve color, light, size, distance from the camera, focus, and/or placement. Any element in your frame can be used to create contrast by juxtaposing it against its opposing element.

Look at this simple image again. How is contrast being used?



Every object in your frame has a certain importance, a certain **visual weight**. The distribution of this weight directly affects the tension in the frame and where the audience looks. In the example above, what gives the geranium flower its weight? Is it the shape? The color? The placement in the frame?



Let's not forget that the frame is flat and that we are working in two-dimensional space. Let's also not forget that we are looking to create an illusion of depth with our images, or a three-dimensional space.

To help us arrange objects in that two-dimensional space and create the illusion of depth, let's employ a couple of useful tools borrowed from the art world:

- rule of thirds

- perspective

Rule of Thirds

Let's start by dividing the frame into equal thirds, both horizontally and vertically.



Notice how important elements of the frame line up along the horizontal and vertical lines or sit squarely where they intersect.

Aligning objects along these lines, or where they intersect, is known as the **rule of thirds** and is extremely useful in creating visually powerful shots.

The rule of thirds helps create a sense of **balance** in your images. It generates tension between opposing areas in the frame.



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Let's also not forget that we are looking to create an illusion of depth with our images, a three-dimensional space.

Perspective

Specifically in art, this is a drawing method that creates depth by manipulating the appearance of objects based on their distance from the viewer.

This illusion of depth revolves around the idea of a **vanishing point**, which is the point on the horizon toward which everything recedes. As objects get closer to the vanishing point, the way they look changes and mimics how we perceive things in a three-dimensional world.

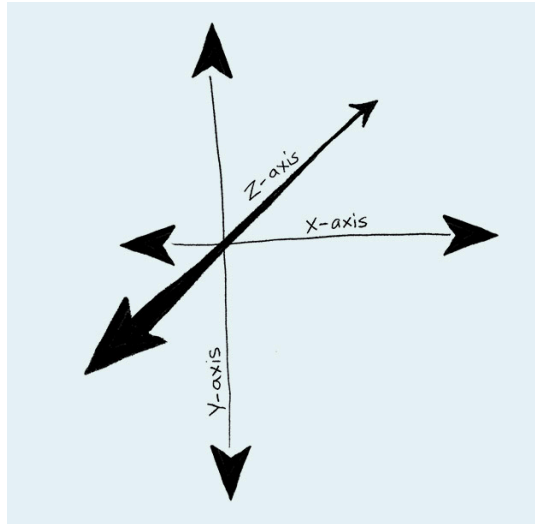


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Certain visual cues, known as **depth cues**, let us understand how far an object is from us.

A good guide for thinking through depth cues is to consider the three axes of any three-dimensional object: the x-axis, the y-axis, and the z-axis.



It is the z-axis that provides the basis for all perceived depth.

Do you remember your visual planes?

- foreground
- midground
- background

Many depth cues relate directly to how the image changes based on its placement along the z-axis (in other words, on which visual plane it is located).

By examining some of these cues, you can utilize them in your work.

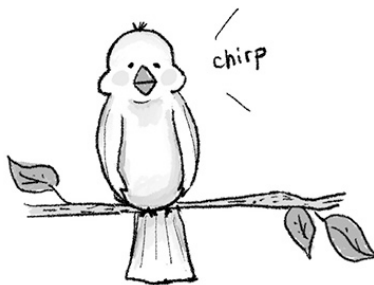
Armed with a solid understanding of composition and how it affects the audience's experience of an image, experiment with your own shots.

As always, make sure you know what you want to say. This will help you have a better understanding of where to place the camera, what to include in the frame, and how to use your composition to accomplish your emotional goals.

Above all, have fun exploring.

No matter whether you are doing this through color separation, light and shadow, or the placement of visual components, the tension you generate will make your audience feel.

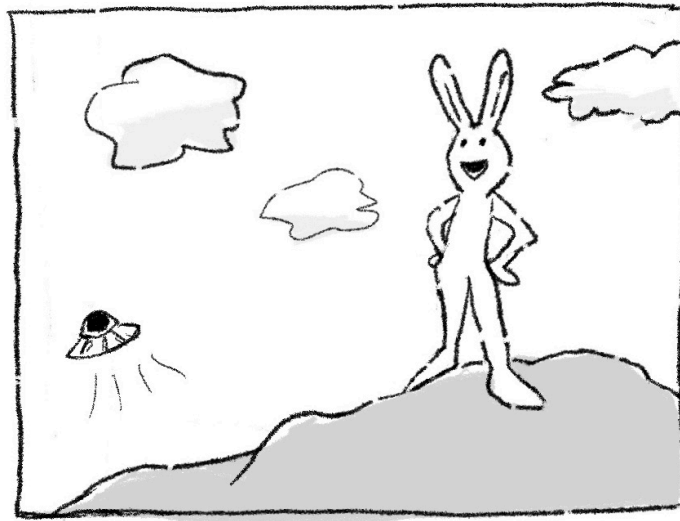
The trick is to make them feel what you intend.



Angle

The angle you use to show your content directly affects the emotion that the audience will experience.

Looking down on something is very different from looking up at it or looking at it head-on. How we perceive the world around us is heavily impacted by the angle at which we view it. Consider the difference between how a small child views the world versus how a full-grown adult views it.



So, where should you put your camera?

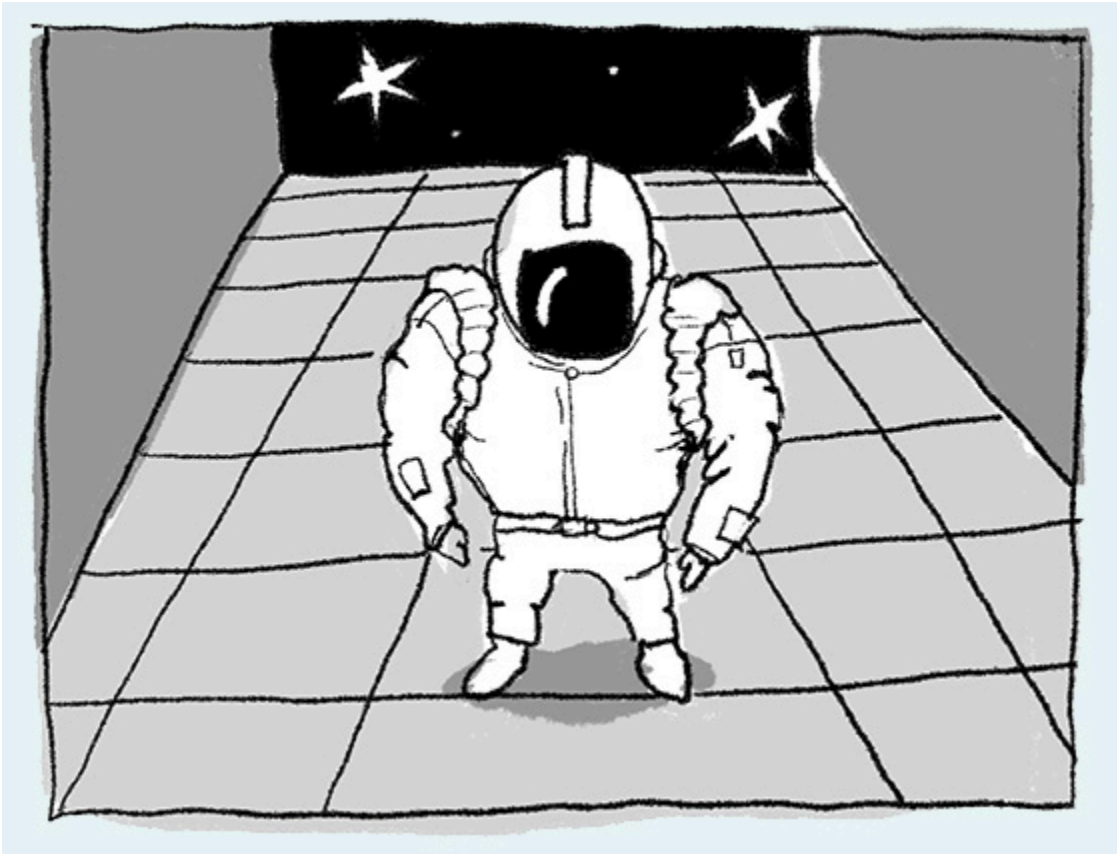
This depends on what you are hoping to accomplish with your shot. Different perspectives are going to make the audience feel differently about what they are looking at.

- Is the character weak or strong?
- Does the audience feel at ease or sense that something is wrong?
- Is the audience involved in the scene or watching from afar?

Here are several different angles and the emotional impact that they have.

High

This angle can make the subject look small and inferior.



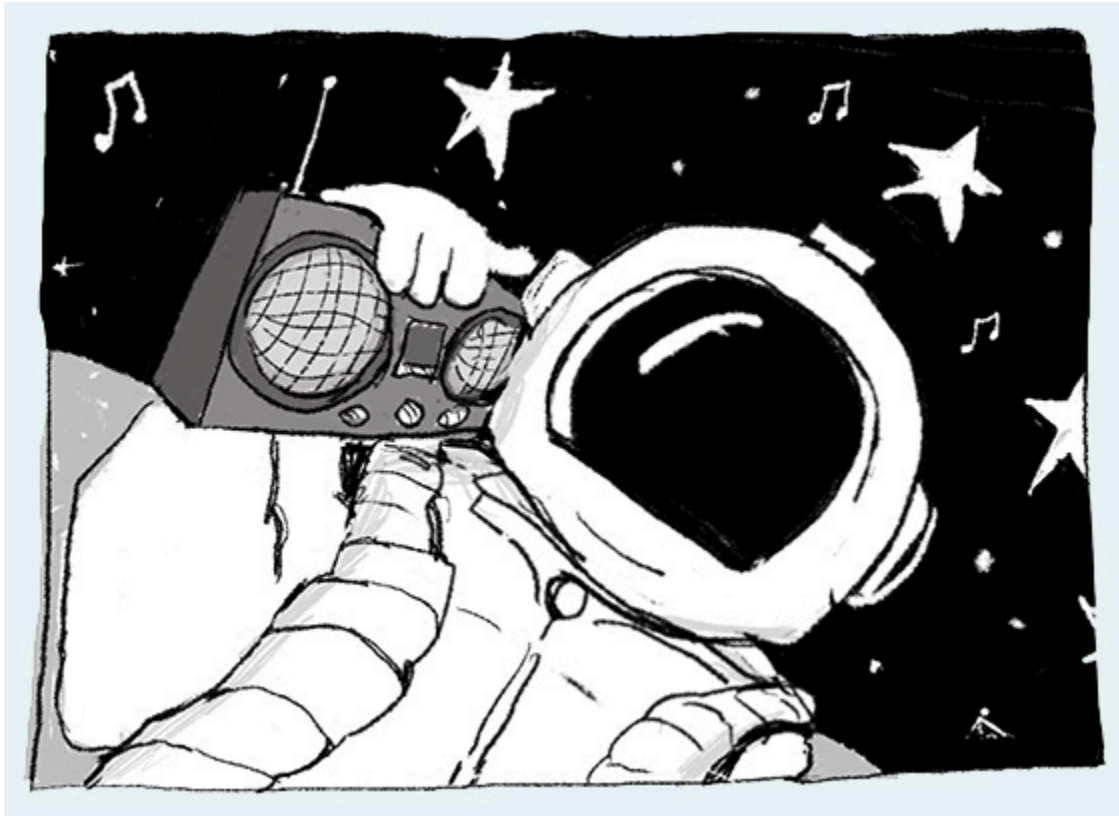
Low

This angle can make the subject look large and powerful.



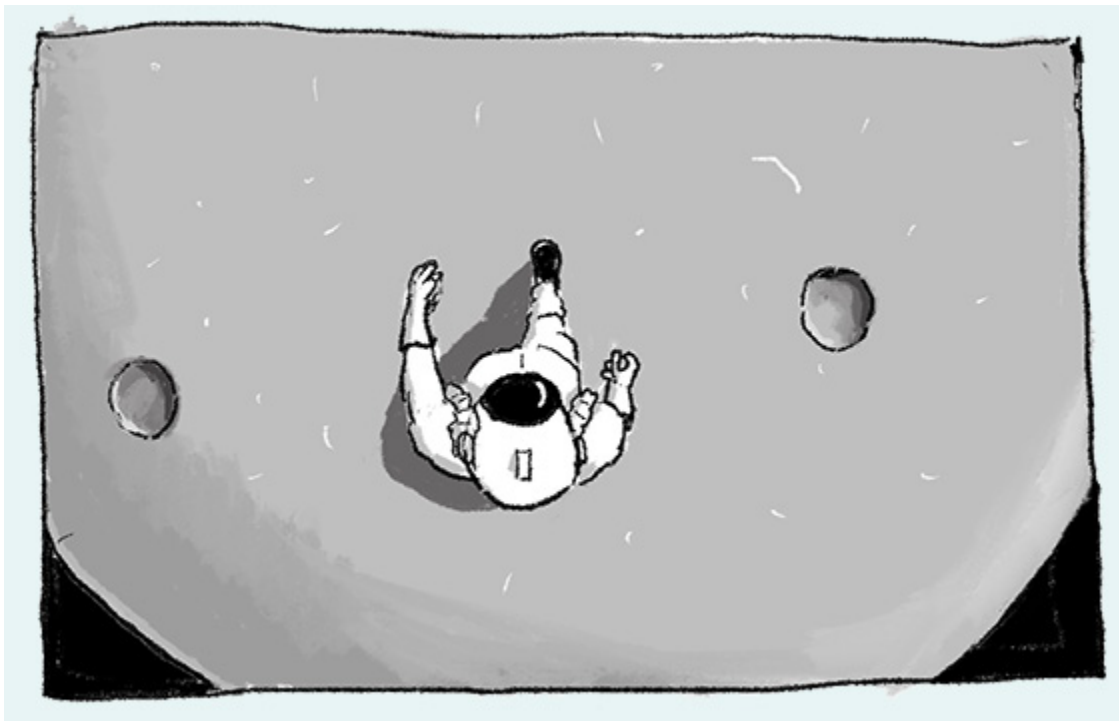
Dutch/Canted

If your image isn't level or is tilted in some way, it can have an unsettling effect on the audience. It can be a way to indicate that things are not "okay."



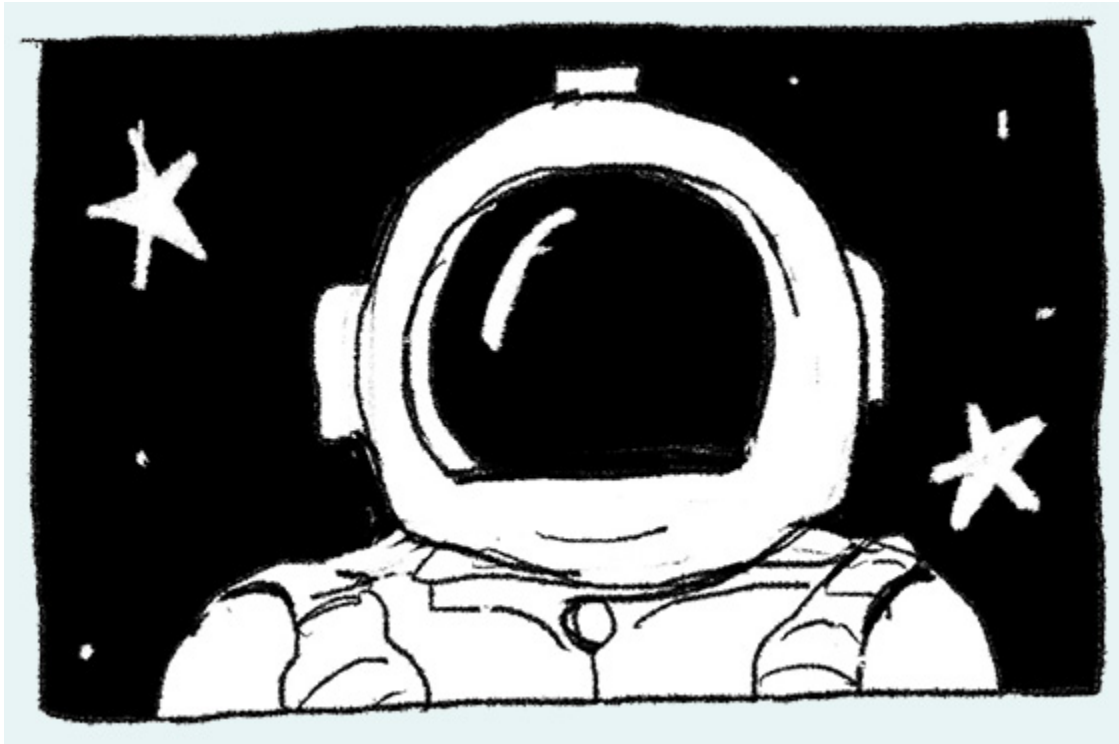
Aerial/Bird's Eye

From this angle, a shot can have a “god-like” quality, giving the impression of being all-knowing and all-seeing.

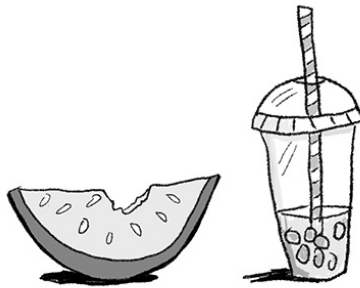


Eye Level

This could be used to connect the audience to the subject, making them feel like equals or at ease.



Be wary of placing your camera at eye level without a good reason. An eye-level approach should *not* be your default starting point. Rather, use eye level with as much care and consideration as you would any other angle of view.

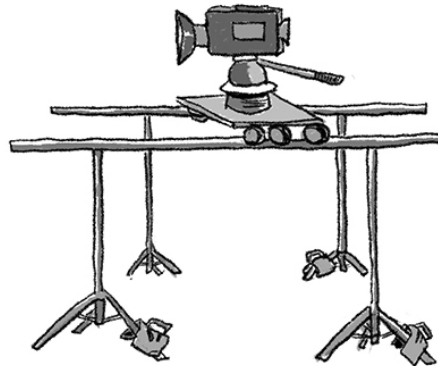


Movement

One of the greatest freedoms you have as a filmmaker is the elegance that can be added to a shot by incorporating movement into it.



Allowing your audience to be carried through a space, rather than simply witnessing a scene from a distance, gives the camera a pulse and heightens the emotional impact of the image. It also gives you another way to manipulate the audience's eyes.



Let's learn the correct terms to describe movement.

Pan

This refers to left-to-right (or right-to-left) movement from a fixed axis point.

This is one of the most foundational moves that is available to you, and you are likely familiar with it if you have ever put your camera on a tripod.

All right-to-left (or left-to-right) movement from a fixed axis point is considered a pan. This will also be true if you are holding the camera and rotating your body.

Note: You can *only* pan right or left. You *cannot* pan up or down.

Tilt

This refers to up and down movement from a fixed axis point.

This is the other foundational move available to you, one you are also likely familiar with.

All up and down movement from a fixed axis point is considered a tilt. This is also true if you are holding the camera.

Note: You can *only* tilt up or down. You *cannot* tilt right or left.

Dolly

This refers to in-and-out movement with the camera mounted on a moving apparatus.

Note: You can *only* dolly in or out. You *cannot* dolly in any other direction.

Track/Truck

This is a rightward or leftward movement with the camera mounted on a moving apparatus.

Note: You can *only* track or truck right or left. You *cannot* track or truck in any other direction.

Ped (Pedestal)

This refers to the up and down movement that occurs when the camera itself moves up and down.

A ped is very different from a tilt. A tilt is performed with the camera in a fixed axis point, but a ped occurs when that axis point itself moves up and down.

Mostly, peds are performed with the camera mounted on a moving apparatus (a dolly or jib).

Note: You can *only* ped up or down. You *cannot* ped in any other direction.

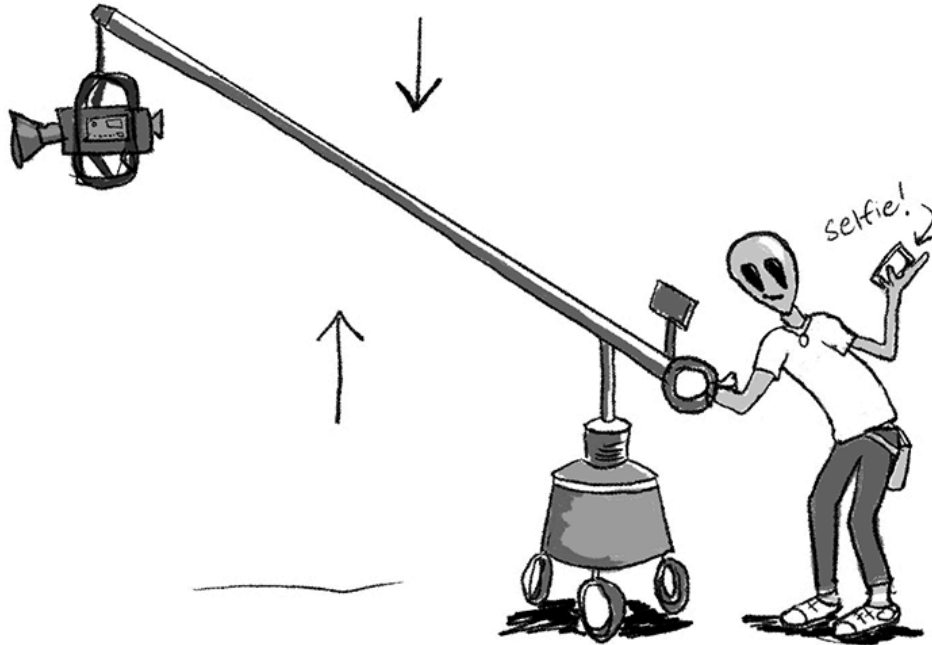
Making movement possible often requires specific equipment. Different equipment will result in different types of movement and will consequently have different emotional impact.

Here are a few types of equipment:

- **dolly:** A dolly is a wheeled platform that allows for controlled and smooth movement. There

are many different types of dollies available, but even a skateboard can serve as one.

- **jib:** A jib is a crane-like apparatus that can create highly dramatic, swooping shots. Think of a jib as a mini crane.
- **gimbal:** A gimbal is a handheld support system that keeps the camera stable and level. Gimbals afford great flexibility of movement, but the weight of a camera (and its accessories) must be considered.
- **handheld:** Without the aid of any apparatus, you will create lifelike, possibly jerky movement. Be warned: this is the most difficult of all camera movements.



Even the smallest movement can add tension and excitement to a shot. Imagine a slow dolly in on a character as they come to a realization. Or a pan away from an action just as it starts, allowing the audience to imagine rather than see what is happening.

There are so many ways that movement can enhance how you convey meaning with a shot. Embrace moving your camera in all the ways you can.

THE EDIT

In this chapter you will learn:

- How to define editing.
- Essentials of a digital medium.
- Continuity vs Montage editing approaches.

Have you ever said the words “I love you”? What do they mean?



In truth, what you hear is little more than a collection of sounds created by a combination of air and vibration, an interplay of your breath, vocal cords, and tongue.

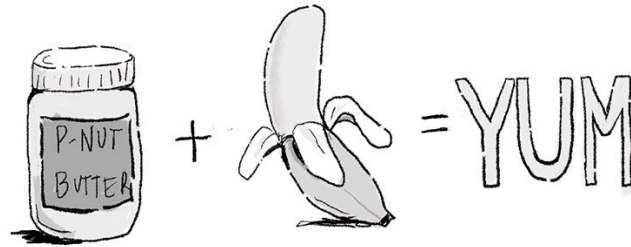
Each word by itself has its singular meaning, but when combined, “I love you” carries tremendous emotional weight.

Words, which are used in everything from shopping lists to philosophical diatribes to haiku, have the power to elicit a wide range of emotions in an audience.

Shots spark emotion.
Making the audience feel
More than words can say.

Like words, shots carry tremendous emotional weight, yet they are just clusters of pixels.

Much like a writer combines words into a precise sentence to convey a specific meaning, we combine shots into a series of precise edits to convey meaning on the screen.



Shot

A shot is an uninterrupted segment of motion picture time.

Edit

The edit is the connection of shots into a meaningful whole.

Consider the following equation: $1 + 1 = 3$.

(To think that all these years you thought $1 + 1 = 2$.)

As a filmmaker, $1 + 1 = 3$ is the most important equation to know because it calculates the meaning created when you combine shots. Specifically, it is the equation that explains editing.

Editing is the juxtaposition of images to create meaning that is greater than the sum of its parts.

Be it a shot of a woman's face, a bird in flight, or a crack in the pavement, every image has meaning unto itself.

Consider the following images. What meaning do they each individually have?



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<https://lmu.pressbooks.pub/filmmaking/?p=550#h5p-25>

The moment you juxtapose one image against another, as is done in the editing process, a third meaning is created. This third meaning doesn't exist until the act of editing occurs.

What third meaning does the juxtaposition of the following images create? Click through to see different versions. How does the meaning change?

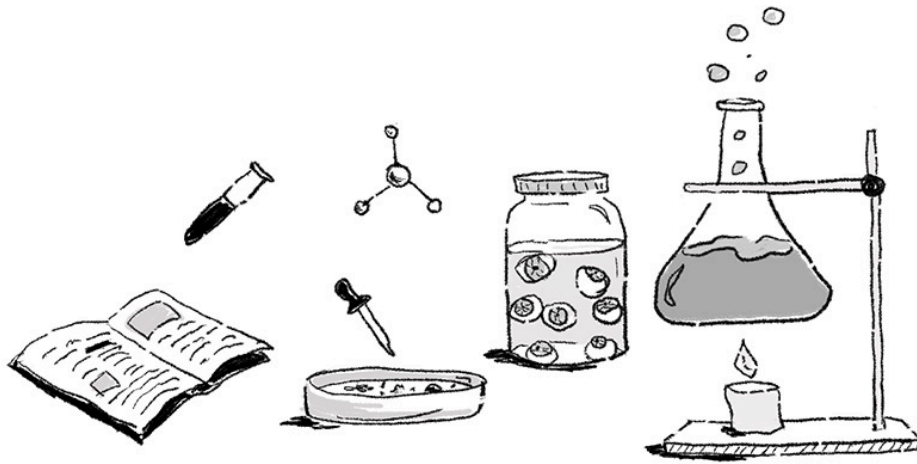


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<https://lmu.pressbooks.pub/filmmaking/?p=550#h5p-44>

There is no right or wrong way to juxtapose images; each arrangement will convey a different meaning. You have to ask yourself which meaning is the one that works for you.

A healthy dose of experimentation is required to discover the myriad ways you can combine images to create meaning. It is precisely that sort of experimentation that enabled editing to evolve over the years, progressing from a simple technical side effect to a full-blown art form.



A Digital World

“01001001 00100000 01110000 01100001 01101001 01101110 01101000 00100000 01101101 01111001 00100000
01101111 01101111 01101110 00100000 01110010 01100101 01100001 01101100 01101001 01101000 01111001” – Frida
Kahlo

What are your thoughts on the above quote?

Don’t you understand the language? You use it every single day when you send text messages and emails, check social media, or watch a show on your streaming platform of choice.

The language of the computer is known as **binary code**, and it is a language in which everything from words to images to sounds is translated into a series of ones and zeros. Think of these as little light switches (called bits) that are either “on” or “off,” depending on what they are saying.

In the case of words, letters are represented by eight such “light switches,” with different combinations for each letter. (8 bits = 1 byte).

For instance:

- “A” is represented as 01000001.
- “B” is represented as 01000010.
- “C” is represented as 01000011.

So, if we translate Kahlo’s quote back into English, it reads as follows.

“I paint my own reality.”



Technological innovation has always been at the heart of filmmaking, and it has advanced in leaps and bounds since the early days of photography.

You may take for granted the digital world that you live in, but it wasn’t always like this.

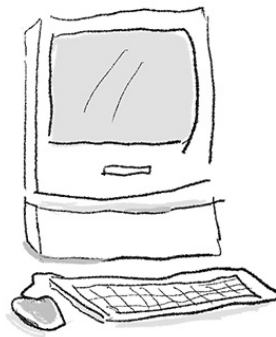
Long, long ago, there were piles and piles and piles of film.

This photographic film was exposed to light by cameras not unlike those of today and then sent to the lab to be developed. There, “work prints” were made from the negative, and these were sent to editors to cut.

Back then, all it took to edit a film was a razor blade for cutting, a roll of splicing tape for connecting shots, and a solid understanding of emotion, story, pacing, and rhythm. Being able to make a strong decision about a cut was essential. After all, when you are physically destroying the film every time you make a cut, you don’t want to get it wrong.

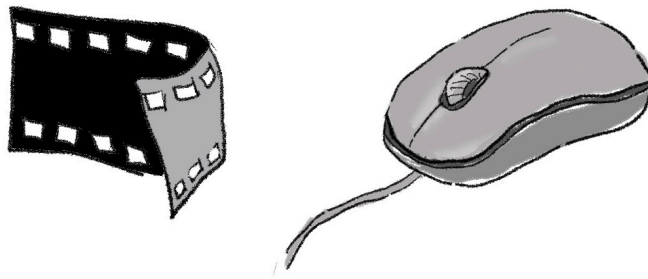
Once the editing was complete, the original negative was cut to match the edited work print, and a series of new negatives and exhibition prints was generated. These new prints were sent to theaters to be screened before a delighted and awed audience.

And then the digital revolution changed everything.



In the past, the work had a much more tactile quality. Everything was physical, from the film itself to the flatbeds, the splicing machines, the Nagra tape, and so on.

What happens when you remove the physicality of the work from the process? How does it change your decision-making process?



Now that we understand where we’ve been, let’s look at where we are now. There are three elements that are essential for working in a digital world.

Processing Speed

At the heart of every computer is a central processing unit (CPU). This is the part of the computer that carries out the instructions given to it—everything from simple addition to complex effect rendering.

Given the vast amount of information contained in even the lowest resolution image, not to mention the number of images required for seamless video playback, computer processors need to be fast. The

faster a computer can process information, the more effective it will be at processing complex video images.

Storage

When you shoot a film or video project, you always shoot more material than you are going to use. This abundance of material, which is the result of multiple takes, varying angles, and so forth, gives you options in the editing room as far as telling your story.

Assume for a moment that you are making a short, 10-minute video. You plan to shoot approximately 1 hour of material, which is a perfectly reasonable shooting ratio. Depending on the format you shoot, you may need anything from 3GB to over 7TB. Do you have a memory card or hard drive that is big enough?

Now, imagine you are shooting a feature-length project. How much footage will you need for a project lasting over 1 hour? How much storage are you going to require?

Storage devices have rapidly increased in capacity over the years. The first mass-produced floppy disks, released in the 1970s and 1980s, had a capacity of between 100 and 300 kilobytes. That's a far cry from the multiterabyte drives that are common today.

Interface

All hard drives are connected to the computer via a cable interface. The cable passes information back and forth between the CPU and the storage device.

Internally, most drives (and motherboards) are connected via a **serial SATA** interface, which is fast and efficient.

Externally, you have several cable interface options:

- **HDMI:** A High-Definition Multimedia Interface (HDMI) cable is commonly used to connect an external monitor or projector.
- **USB:** Universal Serial Bus (USB) refers to a variety of different cable interfaces. There are a few USB interfaces that have become standard for external hard drives that require rapid processing. They include **USB 2.0** and **USB-C** cables, which are sufficiently fast for video work.
- **eSATA:** An external serial advanced technology attachment (eSATA) is another external interface suitable for video editing, but it is less common.

Use the cable interface that meets your workflow needs.

Check the back of your storage device to see which connections are offered.

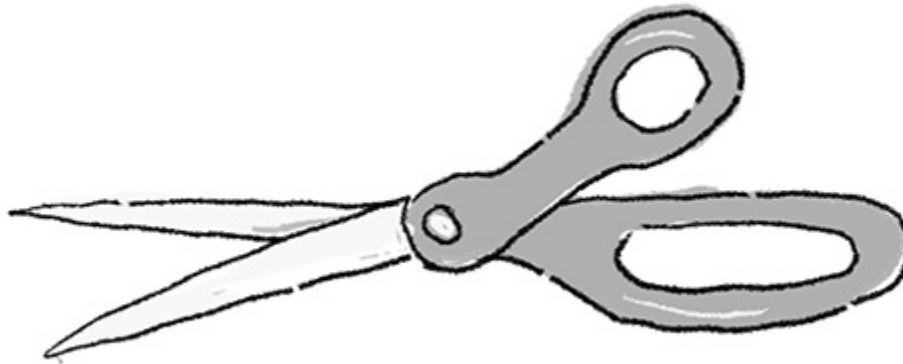


We often talk about issues of speed, such as the speed at which a computer processes data or how quickly a project can be edited now that everything is digital.

Are we really saving time?

Consider the implications of always being able to “undo” a mistake. If you know you can always undo something, how carefully will you make your decisions in the first place?

Remember the editors of yesteryear and how careful they had to be when making a cut.

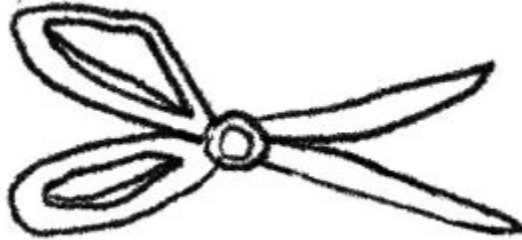


Continuity

You cannot think about the way you construct shots without thinking about how those shots will cut together. Alternatively, you cannot think about how you cut material together without considering how the shots were constructed.

The concept of editing is inextricably tied to shot design and vice versa.

That being the case, you always **shoot to edit**. This is the process by which you consider how the project will be edited and design your shots accordingly.



In much of today's media, the goal is to immerse the audience in the story and dissolve the line between reality and fantasy, between real life and the screen.

As you watch a scene unfold, you might believe that everything is happening as one continuous event. The characters move seamlessly from shot to shot, almost as if there were multiple cameras present, each capturing the same moment from a different angle.

However, this is not the case. In all likelihood, there was only one camera, filming the same action over and over in different ways.

Shooting for continuity is a style that aims for a smooth blend of different shots to create the illusion of a continuous, coherent whole. It immerses the audience in the cinematic space by rendering the editing process invisible, and it generates a sense of continuity in time, space, and action.

The simplest way to shoot for continuity is to use the following approach.

Master Shot

This is a shot in which we can see the whole of the action from beginning to end. It is often a wide shot.

Coverage

These are additional shots that “cover” the same action as the master shot from varying angles and shot sizes.

You shoot the “master shot” first to establish geography, screen direction, blocking, and lighting. It is

often a wide shot, but in truth, it simply needs to be wide enough to show all the relevant action of a scene.

Then, you shoot “coverage” from various vantage points and distances in order to show the various aspects of the scene. For each piece of coverage, the actors run through the same action as was captured in the master shot.

The different shots used are all considered part of the “coverage” of the scene. It then becomes the job of the editor to arrange the way the shots play out within the sequence, cutting for maximum emotional impact.

Look at the following clip and answer the following questions:

- In what way do you feel the continuity of time, place, and action?
- How many distinct shots (as opposed to edits) do you see?



This sequence is made up of three distinct shots. Let’s look at them in detail. Move the slider below the images to switch between shots.



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<https://lmu.pressbooks.pub/filmmaking/?p=610#h5p-35>

Let’s look at another clip and ask similar questions:

- In what way do you feel the continuity of time, place, and action?
- How many distinct shots (as opposed to edits) do you see?



This sequence is made up of five distinct shots. Let's look at them in detail. Move the slider below the images to switch between shots.



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Sometimes you want to break the rules, and sometimes you do it by accident.

If you are looking to create a sense of “discontinuity,” you can break the illusion of continual action by creating a **jump cut**. This is a technique that interrupts the sense of continuity in the sequence.

You can do this by cutting to a shot that is too similar to the previous one or that **isn't** at least 45 degrees different from the previous one. Doing so will create an uncomfortable “jump” for the audience that doesn't feel quite right. The cut itself feels awkward and calls attention to itself.



Alternately, you can cut to the same shot, with the action having “jumped” ahead in time to a different moment or location in the frame.



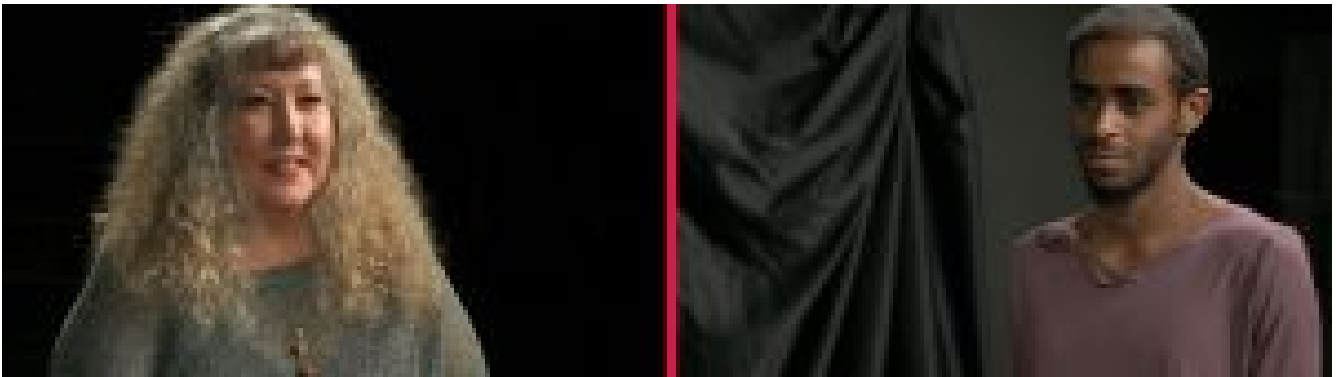
Whatever shots you have, they are all considered part of the “coverage” of the scene. The job of the editor is to arrange how the shots play out within the sequence, cutting for maximum emotional impact.

Screen Direction

Screen direction is the direction a character is facing as they interact with other people or objects within a shot.

Maintaining screen direction is a major factor in preserving the illusion of continuity. However, it can be disrupted if we accidentally place the camera in the wrong position while shooting coverage.

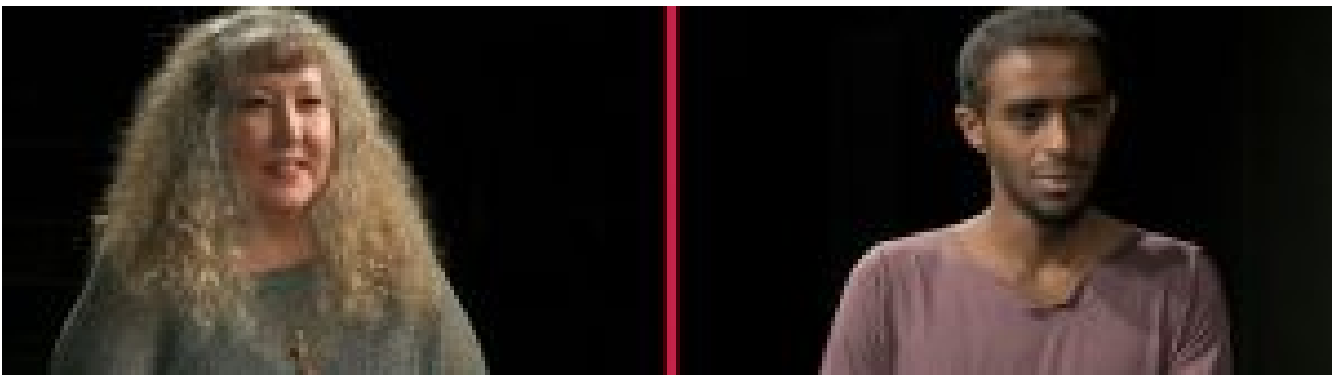
Look at the following shots placed side by side.



The person on the left looks right, while the person on the right looks left. They appear to be looking at each other.

Now look at the following shots.

Are they confusing? Where has the camera been placed to create this situation?



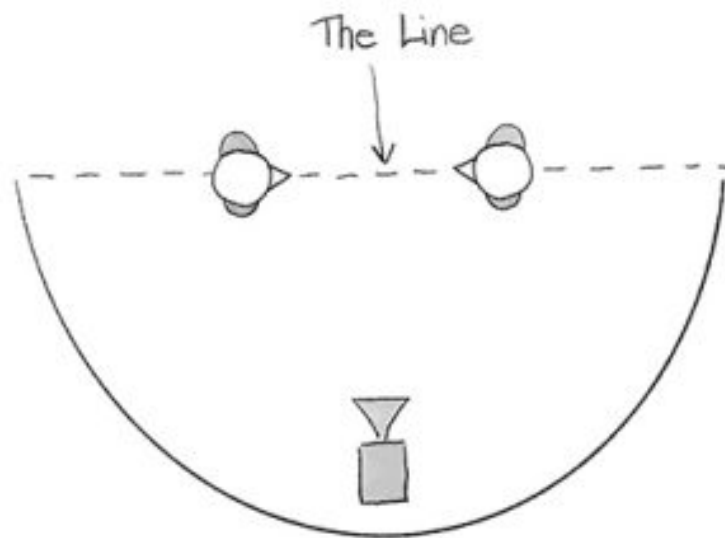
Both people face the same direction, and they no longer appear to be looking at each other.

So, how do we avoid issues of screen direction?

The **180° rule**, also known as the axis of action or “**the line**,” helps maintain screen direction. It is established by drawing an invisible line between the two interacting characters. We then choose which side of the line we will shoot from.



If you want to maintain a sense of “real” space and geography, shoot from only one side of the line.



It is possible to “cross the line” without confusing the audience as to screen direction. However, we can only do that in the following three ways:

1. During the shot, establish a new line by having characters cross the line to create a new one.
2. During the shot, move the camera in an uninterrupted movement across the line to create a new one.
3. Place the camera directly on the line, thereby neutralizing it. In the subsequent shot, place the camera in any position to establish a new line.

Click through the options to see how.



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Montage

Have you ever made a picture collage?

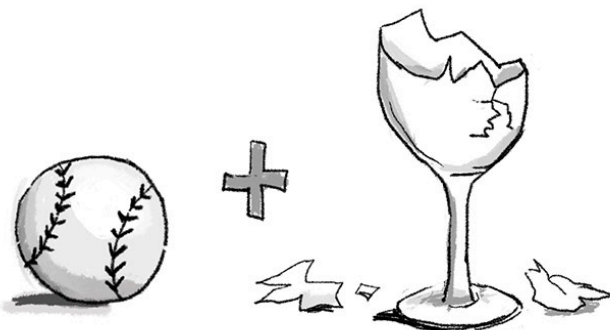


Maybe you've sat with a pile of old newspapers or magazines in front of you, cutting out images that appeal to you and arranging them in a unique and new way. What motivates you to put the image of an apple next to that of a baseball? Or the palm tree next to the fork? Is it the color? The shape? The size? Perhaps it's something about what each image represents that compels you to put them together.

If collage has a cinematic equivalent, it is montage editing.

Montage is an editing style developed in the 1920s by Soviet filmmaker Sergei Eisenstein. It serves as a counterpoint to the immersive linear approach of continuity editing, although both approaches can certainly be used in any project.

Montage frees you from a linear perspective of the world by allowing you to combine shots based on principles of association. These force the audience to be actively involved in their understanding and interpretation of the work.



Whereas shooting for continuity is rife with rules that you need to follow to maintain the illusion of continuous action, montage is unbound by rules. If anything, it invites you to think on a more abstract level.

And if continuity editing enables you to become immersed in the action on the screen, montage compels you to be aware of the editing itself.

Association is key to creating a compelling montage, and there are many different types of associations you can make. What is relevant here is the audience's emotional response to these associations.

Contrasting Associations

Associations can be made by juxtaposing conflicting content:

- happy versus sad
- large versus small
- dark versus bright
- blurred versus focused

How do you feel if you juxtapose an image of a very large dog with that of a small balcony. What associations does that combination of imagery bring up? What about juxtaposing a picnic scene on a bright sunny day with imagery of a dark cage?

Intellectual Associations

Associations can be made using shots that are embedded with cultural meaning:

- religious icons
- pop icons
- public figures

Intellectual associations require that the viewer know something about the content. Using imagery of famous or public figures depends on the knowledge base of the audience. You can't always control how somebody might feel about intellectual content so be careful how you use it. Not everybody feels the same way about a famous individual or religious iconography.

Temporal Associations

Associations can be made to manipulate time:

- condense time
- expand time
- reorder time

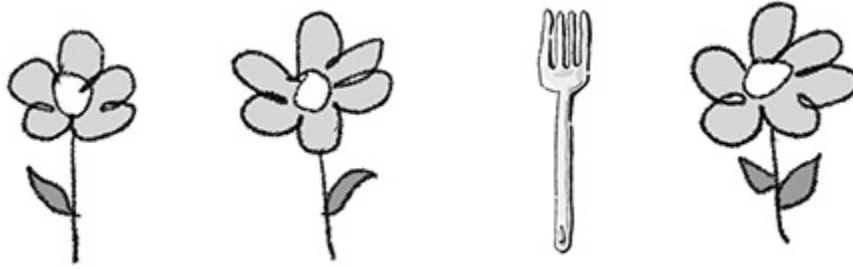
Making temporal associations is all about how you cut the footage to manipulate time. Do you slow something down to make it last longer? Do you repeat the same moment in time (a bit like a gif!) to make it feel like it will never end? What happens when you put things out of order, putting the end before the beginning?

Rhythmic Associations

Associations can be made based on movement within the frame:

- right to left
- up and down

How might it feel to edit two pieces of footage together that both have movement from right to left?
What happens if you cut between something moving to the right and something moving to the left?



Always carefully consider how each shot will be cut together. Remember, each shot is a word, and the connections you make will form your sentence.

Out of this process of experimentation and happy accidents emerges a space where new worlds can spring into being. It's a space where fantastic rules can be created, ignored, or followed, and magic can occur.

Student Perspectives – The Edit

Elaxis Goodwin on constructing story through editing:



Elaxis Ray of “Smile, God Loves You” poses for a portrait during the 2024 Tribeca Festival at Spring Studio on June 11, 2024 in New York City. (Photo by Justin Bettman/Contour by Getty Images)

“One of the biggest things I learned with this film was the power of editing to make or break a project.

I had a lot of things go wrong during production, and for a while, I was trying to force the story together exactly the way it was shot, and it just wasn’t working. After some really helpful notes, I found that the dialogue I had originally in the hair scene wasn’t working with the story. I was able to go back in the edit and recut the scene so you weren’t able to see the mother’s face when she’s giving her lines, and I rewrote the scene and had the actor ADR lines that worked better.

This turned out to be the scene a lot of people connected with the most, and it helped tie the film together much better than the original version had.

This is why I believe that the editing process is not just about stringing together the scenes you shot, but also providing a final opportunity to reconstruct and elevate the film to its greatest potential.”

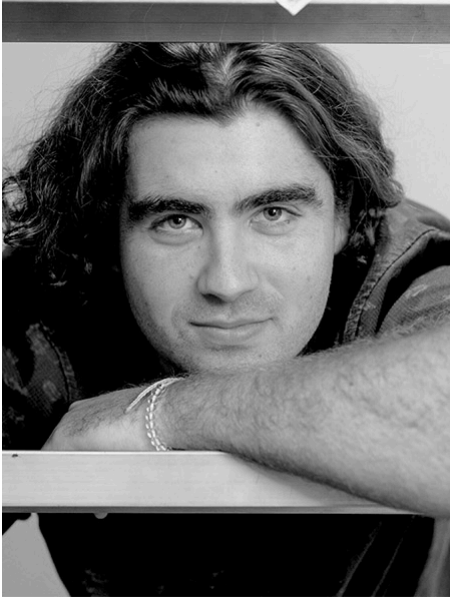
- **Film Title:** *Smile, God Loves You*
- **Logline:** A young girl’s playground reputation is threatened by her mother’s wishes for her to be a church praise dancer.
- **Password:** runmyfade



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Tucker Somberg on fixing problems from production:



“During the process of editing *How’s Diggy?*, I learned just how much editing can not only fix problems from production, but also reveal emotion that lies beneath individual shots.

Like most filmmakers, I encountered endless problems during the shoot. Due to several technical issues, we lost a handful of shots from key scenes. When I looked through the footage afterward, I felt pretty certain that I didn’t have what I needed and that I hadn’t shot the film properly.

After the first edit, it was clear the film as written wasn’t working. I decided to cut the entire opening scene and reorder several others. The first shot we see, Harper on the staircase, is the only image that survived from the original opening. Originally, Harper’s conversation with Tyler at the snack table came toward the end of the film, but I swapped its placement with the scene in which the donation basket is passed.

The placement of the final monologue remained untouched, but my approach to the scene changed significantly from how I had originally envisioned it. It was planned as a long dolly-in that slowly crept closer to Harper. During the edit, I realized this approach dramatized a moment that needed to feel authentic and grounded. Instead, I used alternate coverage that allowed us to sit in a close-up as the actor delivered a beautiful performance.

In the end, the film became an emotional portrait of a young woman desperate to connect and escape her isolation. If I hadn’t been willing to tear down and rebuild what I had created at the script and production level, the film wouldn’t have worked.

This process taught me that we can’t be precious in the edit, and that our only obligation as filmmakers and editors is to make the best possible film — which, more often than not, is different from the one we originally imagined.”

- **Film Title:** *How’s Diggy?*
- **Logline:** At an anonymous meeting, a young woman confronts a past hookup and the isolation she’s been carrying
- **Password:** HowsDiggy2024!



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THE STAGES OF PRODUCTION

In this chapter you will learn:

- What the production process looks like from start to finish.

A film does not begin on a screen.

It begins as an idea, is developed in stages, and involves collaboration with numerous other people.

These stages are similar, regardless of which category a film project falls into (fiction, nonfiction, experimental, or beyond).

Development

Your film begins with a thought bouncing around inside your head. It zooms from left to right and transforms into an idea searching for a way out.

Eventually, it escapes onto a page, but it isn't satisfied to stay there.

Preproduction

With the help of some friends, you coax it forward, slowly but surely.

Production

Then, it leaps off the page and stands before a camera that captures it, one piece at a time.

Post Production

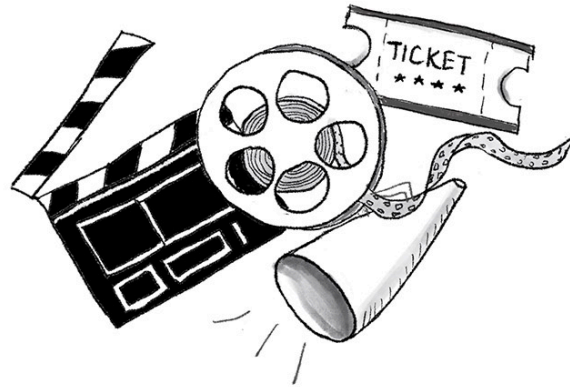
Those pieces are diligently put together, and the film starts to feel whole.

Slowly, it can see, hear, and breathe.

Distribution

Then it begins to dance on its own on a giant screen, where it plays forever and ever for an audience that cheers and applauds and demands more.

As a filmmaker, it is your job to shape your ideas as you enter each stage. You must be able to adapt to the unique set of logistics your film requires. Films may differ in terms of content and form, but the steps taken to bring them to the screen always follow the same five stages.



Development

Development is when you refine an idea into a viable film. This stage will include conducting essential research, having many conversations, experimenting with techniques, and, above all, writing and rewriting.

Preproduction

Preproduction is when you gather all the logistical and creative elements required to make the film. This stage includes everything from hiring crew and securing locations to making creative decisions about the shot design, casting, wardrobe, and everything in between.

Production

Production is generally the shortest stage of the process. This stage includes the physical production of the project (i.e., the shoot itself).

Be sure to shoot everything you require. It can be very difficult, if not impossible, to shoot additional material later.

Postproduction

Postproduction is when you edit the material you gathered during production. This stage requires a lot of polishing and reworking of those materials before you have a film worth screening.

Distribution

Distribution can take many different forms, from theatrical screenings to streaming online. What is important is that you are finished and must now find your project's intended audience.

The scope of every idea is scalable up and down. Customize your project depending on your resources and time.

Be realistic about the challenges you face, and be clever about how to utilize the tools at your disposal.

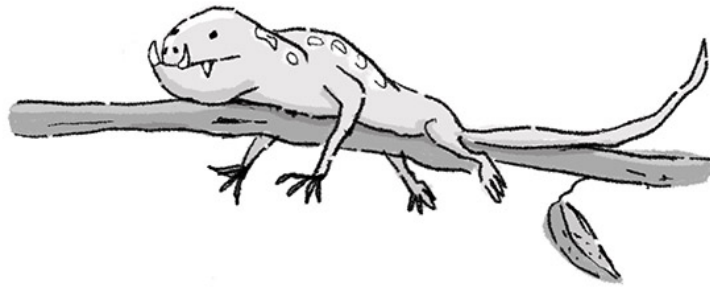
The real test of any project is when it is screened for an audience. The ultimate goal is to give your audience an impactful and immersive experience.

Your film might be personal, but its true value is in how communal it becomes.

Development

Have a good idea for a film? Have something you need to say?

Development is the stage during which you refine your ideas into thoughtful outlines, treatments, proposals, and screenplays. It's about taking those ideas out of your head and putting them on the page.



You might be writing the project yourself or collaborating with others (a writer or a creative producer, for example).

Developing an idea requires research and time. Ask questions and seek answers. Whatever your goal, this is the time to explore a myriad of possibilities and ask yourself some key questions:

- Who is your intended audience?
- What resources are available to you?
- How much time do you have?
- How much money do you have?

Asking these questions and more will help you determine the parameters of your project. Make sure that the scope of your project matches the resources that are available to you.

Note: One of the most valuable aspects of the development phase is that it doesn't have to cost any money. Use this time to explore what you want to say and how you want to say it.

During the development process, there are several building blocks you can use to help you progress from a loose idea to a solid plan.

Ideas are everywhere and can be sparked by almost anything: a feeling, a memory, an event, an injustice, a character, a place, and so on.

Your life experience shapes the lens through which you view the world and will influence your ideas. The films you make express that worldview and are an opportunity for you to share your perspective with an audience. The more you clarify what you want to say, the easier it will be to make key decisions as you proceed. Research your ideas to hone in on what resonates.



Everyone approaches their ideas from different directions, but the goal remains the same:

- What do you want to convey?
- How will you convey it?

Sound familiar? We are right back where we started, still having a conversation about [content versus form](#).

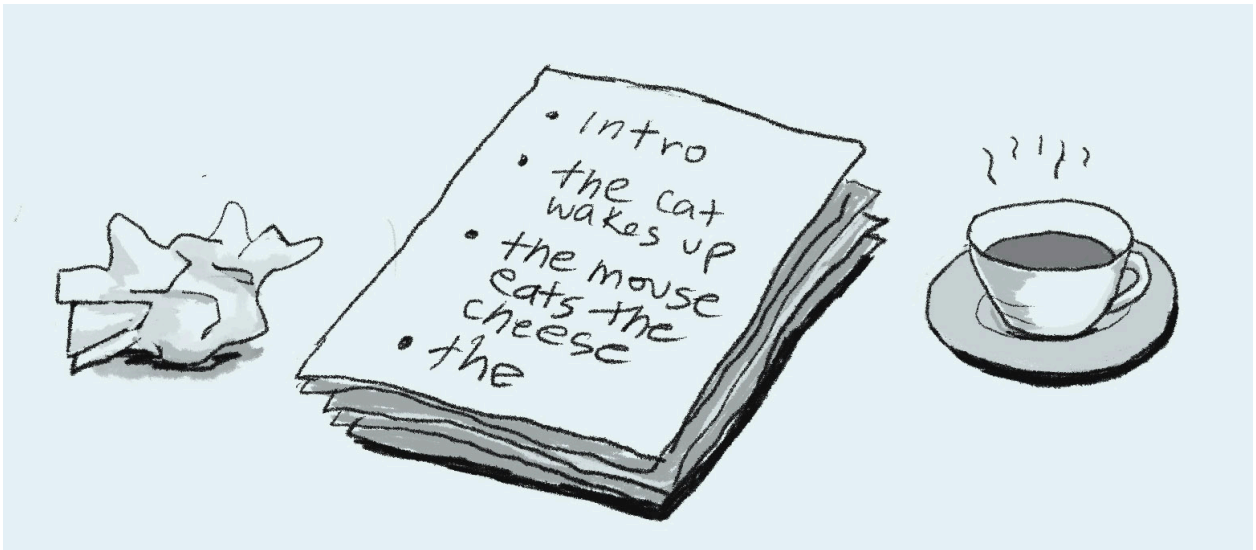
Outline

Get your ideas out of your head so you can see them objectively.

You may have a visual sense of some of the pieces of your project, but not necessarily how they all connect. Creating an outline will reveal what is missing and what is essential.

This takes the form of a list of short descriptions of what happens in each scene, a step-by-step progression of your film. When creating your outline:

- Consider the emotional progression of your idea.
- Figure out the order of key information.
- Determine how it should begin, where it will escalate, and how and when it will end.
- Adjust the order of events to see if there is a more interesting approach.
- Simplify where you can.

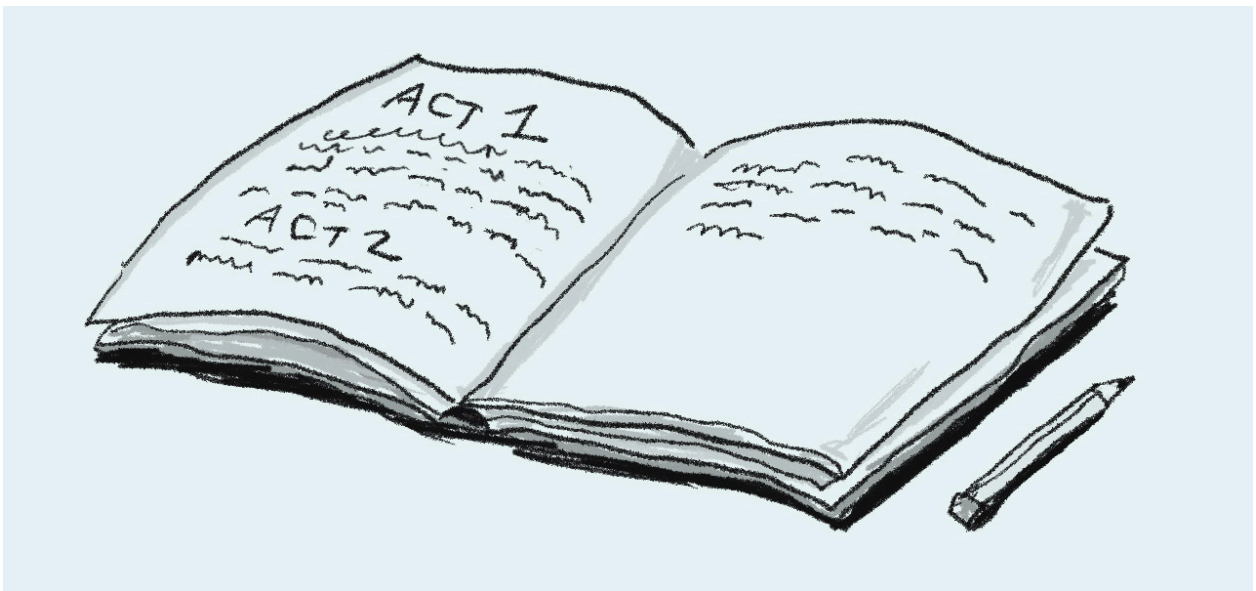


Note: In life, things may happen one after the other. In cinema, things happen one because of the other.

Treatment

A treatment is an in-depth description of what happens in your film from moment to moment. It reads like a short story written in the present tense, and it should include all the essential scenes and characters.

When reading the treatment, one should understand the narrative as well as the general tone and theme of the story being told. Remember, treatments are written in prose form and don't usually include dialogue.



The length of a treatment will vary depending on the length of the project:

- Feature films are usually 10–20 pages long.

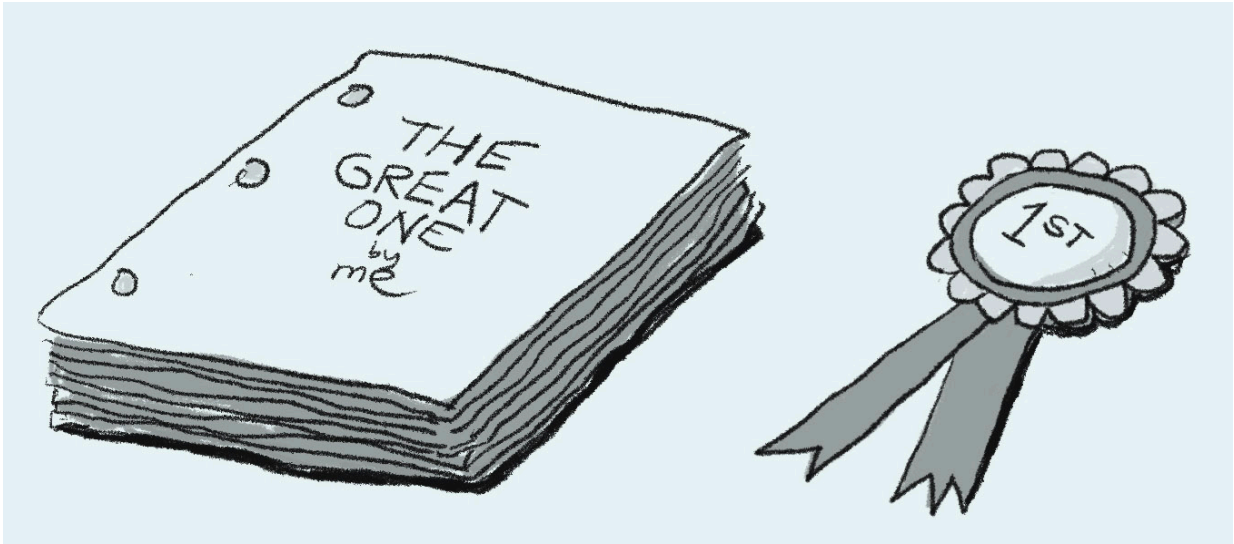
- Short films are usually 1–5 pages long.

Write more than you need so that you can pare it down later.

Screenplay or Project Proposal

Screenplays are written for fiction projects, whereas **project proposals** are written for nonfiction.

They are, quite simply, the blueprint for the finished film.



Screenplays should be written succinctly and use two basic elements:

- **action:** what we see
- **dialogue:** what we hear

Screenplays are always written in the present tense. Furthermore, although a narrative may delve into the inner thoughts and emotions of characters, screenplays only show what is happening.

Find ways to visualize internal thought through external behavior and action.



Project proposals map out all the key elements, research, and rationale needed to understand

the subject and central question of the nonfiction (documentary) project. They communicate the feasibility of a nonfiction film project for collaboration and funding purposes.

Include descriptions of the creative approach and the logistical strategy for production in your proposal.

It is also important to state both your goal as a director and what the audience will learn from watching the final film.



Ideation and writing are not linear processes. You might find yourself circling an idea and trying out different approaches before you figure out how to move forward. You might write a treatment only to reach the end of it and realize that it's not quite saying what you intended. Rework and rewrite as needed. It's okay to delete everything and start over. Your goal is to find the conviction in what you are saying.



There is no wrong way to do this. There is, however, *your* way of doing it. Your process is unique to you, and you should embrace what it takes to get your project where you want it to be.

Long walks in the park? Methodically mapping out every beat on cue cards? Reorganizing your sock drawer? You know what works (and what doesn't work) for you.

The goal remains the same: Develop that idea!

Preproduction

Preproduction is the stage during which you make your movie *before* you make your movie.

It is when your project is broken down into its elements, both creative and technical. It's when many decisions get made and when everything that must happen before filming begins is addressed.

solid preproduction = solid production

With careful planning and a calculated and organized workflow, you are setting yourself up for success.



Using a production binder, in either digital or physical form, will help you keep track of everything that happens during preproduction.

Include sections for each of your production's unique aspects.



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<https://lmu.pressbooks.pub/filmmaking/?p=68#h5p-52>

The more care with which you approach preproduction, the more ready you will be for the challenges of production.



Production

Production is the time during which you shoot all the material for your film. Interestingly, this is the shortest phase of all the phases of filmmaking.

Production comes in all shapes and sizes, depending on the needs of your project. Some productions may have dozens of crew members. Others might only have one or two. A larger crew does not necessarily mean a better shoot. Rather, the quality of your preproduction will determine how successful your shoot winds up being.



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<https://lmu.pressbooks.pub/filmmaking/?p=70#h5p-59>

Whether you are shooting a fiction, a nonfiction, or an experimental project, tailor your production to your specific needs. First and foremost, do what's right for the project!

A short film may shoot over 1–5 days, and a feature may shoot for 21 days or take up to several months, depending on varying factors (budget, availability of actors, etc.).

What is captured during production?

- image
- sound

Camera and sound departments work in tandem to capture all required material.

On set, one is performing the same actions repeatedly:

- prep the shot
- shoot the shot



There is a whole set of protocols in place to make filming easier. Given how complex and often complicated productions can be, these protocols remind everybody what to do at all times. Fortunately, you can remember every step that is required of you by memorizing a key acronym: BLRTS.

BLRTS refers to the order in which we do things as we film each shot. Sometimes you will spend more time on one of these items than on others, but you should always run down the list in your head to make sure you have covered everything.

B – Block

Blocking involves figuring out how the camera and actors move and interact within the space. Blocking actors means figuring out where actors will stand and how they will move during the shot. Blocking camera means figuring out where the camera will be positioned and how it will move during the shot.

Perhaps the camera slowly tracks alongside the actors as they walk along a street. Perhaps one of the actors stops to tie their shoelaces. Perhaps the camera pans to introduce a new character.

Think of your blocking as an intricate dance between the camera and the actors that must be understood by the entire crew so that they can do their jobs accordingly.

For example, the cinematographer needs to understand the blocking of the shot to light it correctly. The sound department needs to know the same so that they can position the boom correctly or utilize other sound gear (e.g., lavalier mics) as necessary. The crew should watch the blocking to inform any decisions they need to make regarding their work.

L – Light

Lights are set or rigged by grip and electric based on the cinematographer's plan.

If this is a master shot of the scene, it may take longer to light than if it is an insert of one piece of the action.

The first time you light a scene will likely take the longest. Subsequent shots may only require minor adjustments.

R – Rehearse

Don't shoot anything without rehearsing it first. This includes rehearsing with the actors and rehearsing any camera movement. Rehearsal is an essential step that will enable you to iron out any issues that may arise and avoid wasting time later.

The rehearsal process can happen as other departments are prepping for a take, but you can also ask to hold the work in order to conduct a rehearsal.

Do not shoot the rehearsals.

As mentioned above, the rehearsal process is essential for ensuring a strong take. It requires that the actors and crew focus on the mechanics of the shot to smooth out any problems. Shooting a rehearsal will change the focus of those involved and won't allow them to make necessary corrections or adjustments as they work.

T – Tweak

With the rehearsal concluded and in anticipation of shooting a take, now is the time to make any final tweaks or adjustments. This may include tweaks to lighting, blocking, camera movement, and set dressing.

S – Shoot

Shoot a take!

Follow the protocol outlined below under “Calling the Shot.”

Assuming you have followed this protocol closely, the chances are very good that you will wind up with a take that you are happy with.

Takes go wrong when the correct procedure has not been followed. This will result in the need for multiple takes, thereby making the process take longer than it should.

Stick to the BLRTS process, and you will save yourself a lot of time and a big headache. Rushing these steps will only slow down the process.

Calling the Shot

This is the protocol used for every take of every shot.

AD: “Quiet on set.” This is an indication that everyone present should be quiet and stop all movement. *Do not delay.*

AD: “Camera ready?”

Camera operator: “Ready.” This is an indication that the camera operator is ready to push record (if it is a take) or rehearse camera movement (if it is a rehearsal). It is also an indication that the assistant camera person is in place with the slate.

AD: “Sound ready?”

Mixer: “Ready.” This is an indication that the sound crew is in place and ready to record.

AD: “Roll Sound.”

Mixer: “Speed.” This is an indication that the mixer has begun recording sound.

AD: “Roll Camera.”

Camera operator: “Speed.” This is an indication that the camera operator has pressed record and is recording. Note: The term “speed” is an indication that the equipment is running at the speed necessary to create sync sound.

When the slate is in place, filling the frame, the scene and take are called (e.g., “scene 3B, take 2” refers to the second take of the second shot for scene 3).

Note: Do not use funny words to indicate which shot it is. “Three baker” is preferable to “three bunny.” It is not the job of the assistant cameraperson to make people laugh. Furthermore, laughter can be very disruptive and disrespectful to the director and actors.

The slate is then removed.

Camera operator: “Ready.” This is an indication that the camera operator is ready. They may have had to adjust focus or framing after the slate.

Director: “Action.” This indicates that the action may begin. This includes any previously rehearsed action, such as camera movement and performance.

The shot plays out as rehearsed.

Director: “Cut.” This is an indication to all that the shot is over. The sound mixer will stop recording, as will the camera operator. Actors will stop performing.

Note: At the conclusion of a shot, simply move to the next shot and repeat the same order of events. Throughout the day, you may repeat the BLRTS sequence multiple times.

A typical production day involves the following:



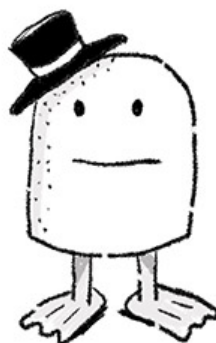
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In many ways, production is simply a matter of solving one problem after another. Things will go wrong. Equipment will malfunction. Actors will forget their lines. The weather won’t cooperate. The boom will get in the shot. The focus will be off. Time will run out. And on and on and on.

Stay calm, address the issues as they come up, and remember that things may not always go according to plan. However, if you remember what your ultimate goal is (what you are saying with this project), there are always alternative approaches you can take.

So, stay calm!



Production is exhausting and exhilarating and terrifying and wonderful and terrible and amazing and exhausting again. If you’ve made it through production, be sure to congratulate yourself. You deserve it.

Postproduction

Postproduction is the period after you finish shooting and before you release the finished film. This is when all the picture editing, sound work, effects, titles, and so on get done.

Knowing your postproduction workflow will ensure a smooth and efficient experience.

These are the common steps involved in postproduction.



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Distribution

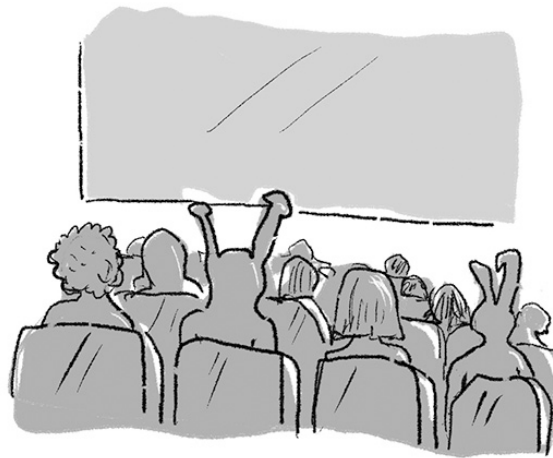
It is often said you are never actually done with a film—rather, it’s done with you. Either way, at some point, it’s time to get your film out there.

But where?

You likely had a good idea of how you wanted to distribute your film from the get-go. It may have been part of your plan from the beginning. Knowing your audience from the start is often part of how you make your films.

You may already know that you want to:

- submit to festivals
- upload to an online platform
- screen for your family, your friends, or just your grandma



Assuming you want to submit your film to festivals, there are several things that you are going to need.

Logline

A logline is a one-sentence description of your film. It generally conveys information about the main character, the basics of the narrative, and the overall message.

For example: A toy rabbit journeys through a magic forest to discover its true nature.

A good logline will make whoever is reading it want to know more, without giving too much away.

Synopsis

A synopsis is a short overview of the narrative of your film. Depending on the length of the film, your

synopsis could be as short as a few sentences or as long as a page. The synopsis for a short film is likely between three and five sentences.

Write this in prose form, covering the main events in the film.

Note: It's okay to give away your ending in a synopsis. The person reading it will likely be a festival programmer who is evaluating the quality of the work and not a member of the general public.

Director's Statement

The director's statement is a short description (one paragraph) of what motivated you to make the film and how you approached it.

You might write about your sources of inspiration, creative process, or aspects of your production. This statement allows you to demonstrate why you are an authority on your chosen subject matter.

Photographs

Assemble the strongest photographs that best represent the work. This should include film stills as well as behind-the-scenes (BTS) shots.

Cast and Crew List

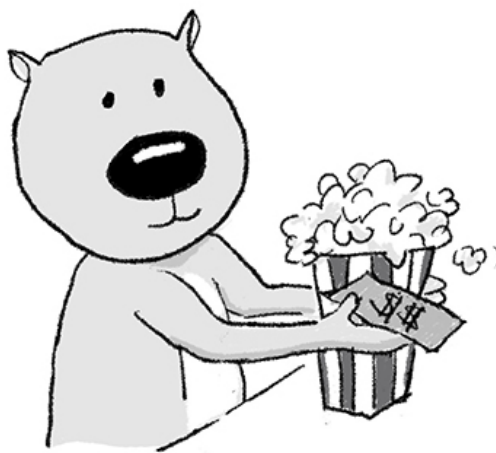
Create a list of all key cast and crew, listing the positions and names of each person involved. Festivals will often include a mention of key collaborators in their materials.

Trailer

Festivals often want a trailer of your film to help promote both it and the festival itself. A trailer for a short film should be no longer than 30 seconds.

When creating the trailer, don't give away everything that happens in the film! Tease your audience so that they want to see more.

Having all these elements ready will make submitting to festivals much easier.



But which festivals should you submit to?

There are thousands of festivals worldwide, many of which have submission fees. You could easily spend a small fortune submitting to every festival out there.

Be smart! Don't break the bank!

Not every festival is a good match for your film. Figure out where you want to screen based on what you hope to achieve.

Are you looking to meet like-minded filmmakers? Do you want to win an award? Do you simply want to get into as many festivals as possible?

Depending on what you hope to gain from your festival experience, a little research goes a long way.

Be smart! Submit to festivals that meet your needs.



Where do you submit?

There are several aggregate websites that allow you to submit to multiple festivals. Two of these are:

- www.filmfreeway.com (primarily U.S.-based festivals)
- www.shortfilmdepot.com (primarily European-based festivals)

Other festivals require you to submit directly from their website.

Be smart! Do your research!



Student Perspectives – Production

Daniel Colella on the challenges of shooting in a swimming pool:



“The physical production of *P.E.* posed unique challenges, as filming in a swimming pool demanded careful coordination for a smooth and safe shoot. It was not as simple as grabbing a camera and “diving” right in. Lighting required particular attention; our G&E team positioned all lighting equipment outside the pool area to ensure that wires and gear remained safely away from water. Additionally, a lifeguard was always present to oversee safety and monitor anyone in the pool.

To prepare for the pool scenes, the cinematographer and I conducted tests with an underwater camera housing months ahead of production. This preparation helped us master camera operation and plan complex shots in advance. One notable sequence involved following Ben, the main character, swimming from one end of the pool to the other. To achieve this smoothly, we devised a pulley system using a rope tied to the camera operator’s life vest, which allowed the crew to guide them steadily across the water, keeping the subject perfectly framed.

Given that this was a student production, collaboration with the school’s production safety team was crucial to ensure we adhered to all safety protocols. By meticulously planning and prioritizing safety, our team maintained a professional yet creative environment throughout filming.”

- Film Title: *P.E.*
- Logline: A heavy-set teenager braves the nightmare of P.E. swim class.
- Website: www.danieljcolella.com



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Vahan Bedelian on relying on the people around you:



“I entered film school with the stated goal of making a great thesis film that would perform well in festivals, and I was obsessed with that goal. I studied other films that had played at prestigious festivals, breaking them down into mock shot lists and analyzing the pace and rhythm of their editing. I stayed prolific, shooting three extra short films in addition to the three we were required to make in grad school. I cast my actors a year in advance, even putting a casting notice out on a Korean-language radio station in search of someone to play the mother. I went through twenty drafts of my script, edited my storyboard together with sound effects and voiceover, and spent six weeks choreographing the fight with my stunt team before even bringing in the actors to learn the moves.

You will notice that every one of these sentences begins with the word “I.” That reflects a flaw that existed early on in my creative process. I tried to turn this film into a success through sheer force of will and meticulous planning. I wanted to be one

hundred percent sure that it would work before arriving on set.

But ironically, what made *The K-Town Killer* my most successful short in the end was learning to let go and rely on the people around me. A great example is the scene many people cite as their favorite—the scene of the mother placing an egg on her daughter’s black eye. This wasn’t one of the beats I’d spent months meticulously planning, locked away in my preproduction tower. It was a last-minute suggestion from my codirector, Healin Kweon. Because of this, on the day of production, we were able to let go and allow our actors to discover the scene in the moment while the DP followed them.

Thankfully, this scene came early in the shooting schedule, and I was able to apply the lesson I learned throughout the rest of production. That lesson was a reminder that filmmaking is a collaborative process and that the best moments in cinema require a degree of spontaneity. If you try to force the film to bend to your will, you risk killing that spontaneity. That is the nerve-wracking thing about filmmaking: You’re spending thousands of dollars per day, and you only have one shot to capture the best footage you can. Despite this, I believe it is important to maintain a degree of uncertainty on the day. That uncertainty can be anxiety-inducing, but it’s also the nature of the craft.”

- **Film Title:** *The K-Town Killer*
- **Logline:** A professional fighter hiding her career protects her mother from an abusive landlord.
- **Website:** www.bedelian.com



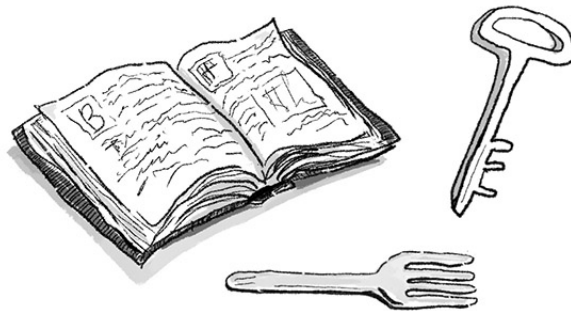
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THE BEGINNING OF SOMETHING ELSE

Hello again!

You made it through our entire book! Well done.

We hope that your head is spinning with all the questions that you never thought to ask. Questions you never knew existed. May each question lead to a new question.



Your questions are the beginning of a conversation you will have for the rest of your life, a conversation that will never grow old and will keep evolving. You will discover a great deal about the human condition by engaging in this conversation. You might even find that you have an understanding about a world so complex that it can only be expressed cinematically.

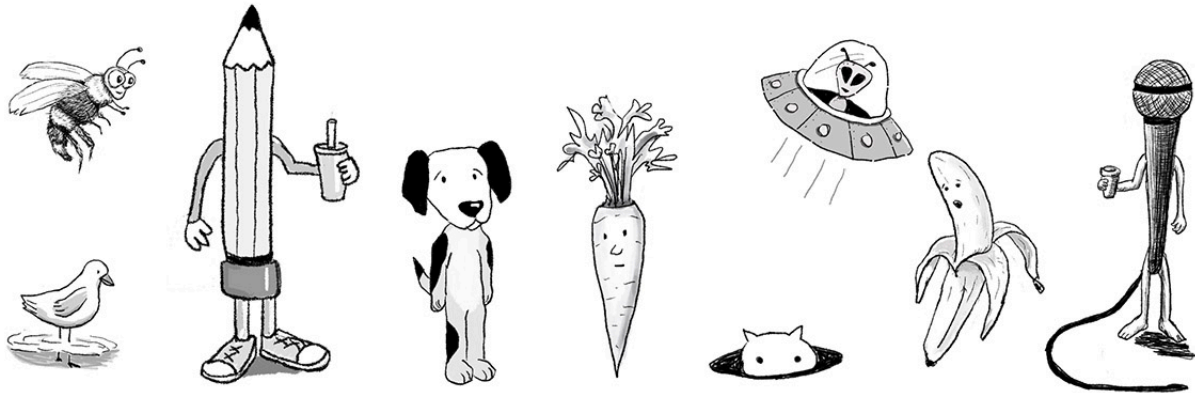
We guarantee that, in time, you will know how to convert amps to watts, how to wrap an XLR cable, and how to load a grip truck the right way. These will be the easy answers that will become second nature with time, experience, and expertise.



More importantly, though, we hope you keep finding new answers to these two key questions:

- What story must you tell?
- What emotion must you share?

Asking these questions will provide you with endless possibilities and new opportunities to learn. They will give you deep insight and always challenge you. They will keep you humble, curious, and open.



Build a broad base of reference and, with it, the ability to connect with people from all walks of life.

Make films that will force the audience to think, question, feel, and connect.

Make a bunch of bad films so you can make one that is truly worthy of their time, a film that allows people to see beyond their perception and share in the delight of a collective experience.

Work hard to earn the trust of your audience.

Work hard to earn the trust of your colleagues.

Do your best, and be generous with your time. Every project you work on will make you better, add to your humanity, and increase your wisdom.

Work with people who are more skilled than you. Lift those who are still learning.

Embrace being both a student and a teacher.

Continue the conversation.

Enjoy the ride.



About the Authors

Jessy and Mischa Livingstone:

Jessy and Mischa are partners in teaching, writing, filmmaking, marriage, and parenthood. Their fully enmeshed existence has inspired a wide spectrum of creative work, running the gamut from music videos to documentaries, experimental films to fiction, and ad campaigns to guerrilla artwork.

They have nurtured hundreds of students, some of whom can claim the honor of being “Livingstoned,” having been taught by each of them.

Two decades of collaboration are the key ingredient to their creative pursuits and professional achievements. This OER stems from their lifelong commitment to the art of conversation, to asking questions and seeking answers, and to seamless collaboration and endless curiosity.

Got some feedback or questions? Feel free to reach out via the following email addresses:

- Jessy – jessicaplivingstone@gmail.com
- Mischa – mischa.livingstone@lmu.edu

Vanessa Newell (Illustrator):

Vanessa Newell is an award-winning filmmaker, artist, and recovering film editor whose real love is putting pen to paper. Her illustrations—wry, snarky, and occasionally side-eyeing humanity—capture everything from her mood to the absurdity of everyday life. Her short films have played at festivals worldwide, racking up awards along the way. When she’s not drawing, making movies, or raising a little hell at protests, she’s teaching film production and media & gender studies in Los Angeles.

Her greatest passions? Social justice and monster movies—preferably together, because who says you can’t save the world while fighting off a giant monster?



Thank You

We wish to thank the following people for their incredible support throughout the development of this OER. Without you, we would have nothing but a pile of tucked-away handouts.

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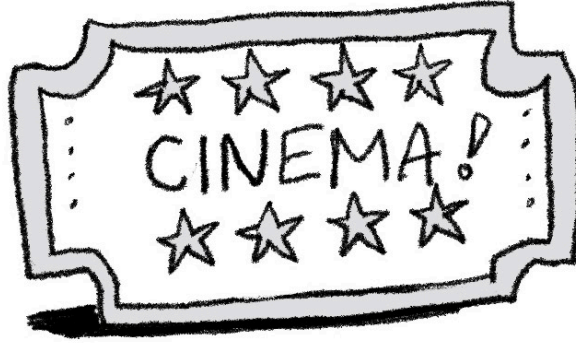
To **Haim Barbalat**, for your keen eye and willingness to go wherever the shot worked best. To **Daniella Crookshank**, for your wonderful abandon and whimsy. To **Gabriel Mantesnot**, for trusting us before you knew us.

To **Rhea Alsharabaty**, **Vahan Bedelian**, **Matthew Cheung**, **Dan Collela**, **Keisha Davis**, **Dakota Fitzsimmons**, **Elexis Goodwin**, **Tucker Somberg**, and **Tapio Tokunaga** for sharing your thoughts, wisdom, and insight, as well as your work.

To all of our **students**, past, present, and future, for making us better teachers and human beings.

And a particular thank you to **anybody** who is reading this book. If we have been able to help you find your voice and become a bolder filmmaker in the process, then we have accomplished everything and more.

Jessy and Mischa



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Accessibility Statement

Accessibility of This Resource

The web version of this resource [No-Nonsense Filmmaking](#) has been designed to meet [Web Content Accessibility Guidelines 2.0](#), level AA. In addition, it follows all guidelines in [Appendix A: Checklist for Accessibility](#) of the [Accessibility Toolkit – 2nd Edition](#). It includes:

- **Easy navigation.** This resource has a linked table of contents and uses hierarchical headings in each chapter to make navigation easy.
- **Accessible images.** All images in this resource that convey information have alternative text and, if needed, linked image descriptions.
- **Accessible links.** All links are descriptive and include a textual reference if they open in a new tab.
- **Accessible interactivity.** Only accessible H5P types are used.

Accessibility Checklist

Element	Requirements	Pass?
Headings	Content is organized under headings and subheadings that are used sequentially.	Yes
Headings	The chosen Pressbook uses either the Jacobs or Malala theme.	No
Images	Images that convey information include alternative text descriptions. These descriptions are provided in the alt text field, in the surrounding text, or linked to as a long description.	Yes
Images	Images and text do not rely on color to convey information.	Yes
Images	Images that are purely decorative or are already described in the surrounding text contain empty alternative text descriptions. (Descriptive text is unnecessary if the image doesn't convey contextual content information.)	Yes
Tables	Tables include row and/or column headers that have the correct scope assigned.	N/A
Tables	Tables include a title or caption.	N/A
Tables	Tables do not have merged or split cells.	N/A
Tables	Tables have adequate cell padding.	Yes
Links	The link text describes the destination of the link.	Yes
Links	If a link will open in a new window or download a file, a textual reference is included in the link text.	Yes
Links	For citations and references, the title of the resource is hyperlinked, and the full URL is not hyperlinked	Yes
Audio	All audio content includes a transcript that includes all speech content and relevant descriptions of non-speech audio and speaker names/headings where necessary.	No
Video	All videos include high-quality (i.e., not machine generated) captions of all speech content and relevant non-speech content.	No
Video	All videos with contextual visuals (graphs, charts, etc.) are described audibly in the video.	No
H5P	All H5P activities have been tested for accessibility by the H5P team and have passed their testing.	Yes
H5P	All H5P activities that include images, videos, and/or audio content meet the accessibility requirements for those media types.	No
Formulas	Formulas have been created using MathML and are rendered with MathJax.	N/A
Formulas	If MathML is not an option, formulas are images with alternative text descriptions.	N/A

Known Accessibility Issues and Areas for Improvement

- This Pressbook is using the Leonard Theme and may not be as easy to read for some as other themes.
- For all videos hosted by YouTube that include captions and transcripts, the captions and transcripts are auto-generated and not edited by a human for accuracy. Therefore, some relevant non-speech content or descriptions may be missing.
- Though all H5Ps used in this Pressbook are accessible, the images used in the H5Ps do not include alt text and therefore may not be accessible.

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We are always looking for ways to make our resources more accessible. If you have problems accessing this resource, please contact us to let us know so we can fix the issue.

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- The computer, software, browser, and any assistive technology you are using that can help us diagnose and solve your issue (e.g., Windows 10, Google Chrome (Version 65.0.3325.181), NVDA screen reader)

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This statement was last updated on *August 16, 2025*.

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